COMMANDER GUIDE TO RELATIONSHIPS

Enhance romantic partnerships, friendships, and parent-child relationships

16Personalities

Table of Contents

Introduction 4

Romantic Relationships 6

Potential Role Pairings 9

Commander-Analyst Romantic Relationships. 10

Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships. 15

Commander-Sentinel Romantic Relationships. 21

Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships. 26

Conclusion. 31

Friendships 32

Commanders and Friends from Other Roles . . 34

Commander-Analyst Friendships 34

Commander-Diplomat Friendships 40

Commander-Sentinel Friendships 45

Commander-Explorer Friendships 50

Conclusion. 55

Parenthood 57

Parenting for Each Stage of Development . . 60

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years). 60

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years) 64

Preschool to School Age (3–5 Years). . . . 68

School Age (5–12 Years) 74

Table of Contents

Adolescence (12–18 Years) 79
Conclusion. 85
Final Words 86
So... What's Next? 88

Introduction

Why Relationships Matter to Commanders

Few personality types can match the strength that Commanders offer to those they love. Commanders use their intellect, imagination, and determination to support the people they're close to – and they often enjoy being such a hub in their social world. Of course, developing bonds with people can depend on how Commanders present their energy, and these types often put minimal emphasis on emotional understanding. While they might offer solid and sincere virtues, they aren't always very delicate or sensitive in the way that they relate to friends, family, and romantic partners.

As energetic idealists, Commanders can be deeply caring, but they often unconsciously forego empathy in favor of what feels like a more rational solution. Despite their best intentions, this can create disconnection – or even disaffection – at times. Concerned with social standing, though, Commanders have good reason to value others' feedback. Consciously developing and utilizing emotional intelligence skills helps these types create extremely rewarding social bonds by letting them both give and receive forms of energy ranging from love, tenderness, and joy to exuberant, witty humor and constructive criticism. When it comes to those they love, Commanders can be guided by their firm principles to prioritize the well-being of others and stand as kind guardians.

Social Engineers

Commanders are known for being conscious tacticians in many areas of their lives. They get an idea, figure out a plan to make it happen, and then take deliberate action each step of the way. They tend to enjoy the process of shaping their environment and the events in their lives, even if they must sometimes adjust their methods (and views) to achieve their goals. For Commanders, the world around them often seems like an enticing collection of components that can be arranged or leveraged in some beneficial fashion.

Some may think it odd to view the social realm similarly, but when Commanders are motivated by love, respect, and positive intent, they can deliberately engineer their social relationships in healthy ways. It's immensely rewarding to play a meaningful role in the lives of others and to be the one responsible for creating something beneficial.

Commanders pride themselves on their efficacy, and they have abundant energy and imagination. When they turn these strengths to the social world, they find a sense of satisfaction in applying their abilities – and in being agents of change.

Such engineering could be as simple as mediating between friends when they disagree or offering a loved one advice and assistance to navigate an obstacle. Or it could be something broader, like organizing a community action group around a common cause or need. Of course, it needn't be an idealistic or altruistic goal – Commanders might simply revel in occasionally playing the social lead, hosting a block party, for example, or heading up family gatherings. But social engineering could also mean dedicating themselves to a deep, long-term commitment, like building a fulfilling marriage or raising a healthy, happy child. Relationships offer Commanders nearly infinite opportunities to craft something significant and worthy, whatever the scale, and exercising that power can be uniquely satisfying.

Challenges and Rewards

For a personality type that's so often focused on mastering intellectual and technical goals, the social world can seem like a stormy sea at times. It features unexpected highs and lows, unreasonable irrationality aplenty, and numerous other wayfarers with their own motivations. Sometimes the complexities and challenges of social relationships may make Commanders question their investment of time and energy. They might not feel pulled to approach their social connections with the same zeal that they devote to other areas of life. Yet the vigorous currents of the social world are difficult to resist, and many rewards beckon despite the turbulence.

When Commanders do turn their focus to social ends, it's with the same forceful intent that drives their exploration and endeavors in any part of life. For these personality types, challenges exist to be overcome, and Commanders welcome any opportunity to prove themselves and earn whatever grand rewards life has to offer. Relationships are full of surprises, and when Commanders embark on an interpersonal journey with another – be it a partner, friend, or child – little stands in the way of them discovering the joyful rewards that await.

Want to boost your understanding of the traits that make up your personality type, and the theory behind them? Learn more here.

Romantic Relationships

Even in love, Commanders are likely to have a set of goals – and a plan to achieve them. The task of trusting others in love is a bold adventure that takes them into uncomfortable, unknown territories. However, when they find the courage to loosen their grip in deference to others they love, they'll experience and enjoy more balance in their lives.

Although they may face many challenges (like every other personality type), Commanders who are looking for love still see the value of solid romantic partnerships. Their attempts may not look like the conventional images of romance, but these types ultimately desire love and connectedness like anyone else. As Extraverts, they draw energy from others, and loving, attentive partners can be quality power sources. This alone makes the challenge worth it.

Passion That Runs Deep

Connection is an essential human need. Romance and love are among the strongest expressions of connectedness, but not everyone experiences these expressions in the same way. Commanders may not fit easily into the conventions that surround dating, love, and marriage. However, when they make a partnership commitment, Commanders can be incredibly stable, loving partners. Relationships with them may not be filled with fireworks, but less flamboyant romances can still be powerful ones.

Romance, especially of the passionate variety, is more likely when Commanders feel that their partners are also interested in increasing their knowledge and pursuing goals with gusto. A shared passion for

achievements – even if the goals they hope to achieve are nothing alike – is more stimulating to Commanders than candlelit dinners (unless they're discussing their goals at said dinners). Their passion is likely to take the form of arousing conversation, and their idea of a romantic gesture may be letting their partners decide where to go for dinner without criticizing their choices. (Internal dialogue: "That restaurant only has a three-star review? Are you sure you want to risk it?" External dialogue: "Sure, honey, that sounds fantastic. It could be a fun experiment.")

Struggling with Emotional Connection

Although their feelings are as strong as anybody's, Commanders may not be emotionally demonstrative. Their Extraversion makes them adept in social situations, but the awareness needed to navigate through more emotionally fraught environments may be somewhat superficial, and learned rather than heartfelt. This may extend to dating and other romantic scenarios. Hopefully, as their relationships mature, Commanders tend to access their honest feelings more and use them to strengthen romance. When trusting only their rational instincts and dismissing any alternative thoughts from their partners, however, they don't always supply the requisite empathy required of lasting relationships.

Additionally, Commanders in less-evolved relationships may struggle with their desire to analyze and solve every perceived problem. They often don't realize that people experiencing emotions aren't always looking for solutions – sometimes they just need an empathetic ear. Commanders see pain and try to fix it, and they're the type most likely to agree with the statement, "You believe there's a right or wrong answer to every question in life." For them, there's a definitive solution for every problem. Everything is a part of a system that, if broken, just needs rethinking or readjusting to be repaired.

Unrealistic Relationship Expectations

Since Commanders spend much of their lives strategizing and analyzing situations, they may find it challenging to match their imaginative expectations with hard reality. They're among the personality types most likely to say that their attitudes about relationships change

frequently. (Shifting attitudes about relationships are shared by those with the Intuitive trait, who spend much of their time in their imagination-fueled mental playgrounds.) The troubling question for Commanders may be, "Is there a perfect, rational formula for this thing called love?" Even if they believe they've found one, next month, with more "data," their formula might transform completely. Their wishes can be a moving target.

Another area where Commanders may find themselves struggling to be realistic is the romantic expectations of their partners. Commander lovers don't always appreciate the layers of rituals involved; in fact, they often feel they're superficial and unnecessary. For example, buying their sweethearts bouquets of flowers that are just going to wither and die ("Really, you know they're already dead, right?") seems impractical and an inefficient use of funds at best. They may fail to see that such rituals often have a purpose that has more to do with emotional intelligence than logic. Commanders who reject such rituals may find themselves struggling to find significant others who are willing to overlook their disregard for anything that isn't "entirely logical."

Embracing Emotional Expression

Learning to understand the role their emotions play within their romantic relationships, and having the ability to communicate them effectively, are both particularly important for Commanders. Effective communication in romance must include feelings, whether they appear to have a rational purpose or not. The best way for individuals of this type to sort through both their own and their partners' emotions is to take the time to intentionally and regularly talk about their feelings.

Commanders can avoid over-intellectualizing their emotions by sharing them and allowing for their partners to provide additional unique perspectives. Doing so improves their relationships as well by encouraging them to engage their lovers in conversation and to truly listen to what they have to say. They will get more accurate information about how their partners feel if they ask rather than assume. Intentional communication about feelings is a win-win situation for Commanders and their love interests alike.

Establishing Reasonable Expectations

Commanders are by no means the only personality type with unrealistically idealistic expectations of future partners and relationships. Although it's certainly helpful to have a set of traits to look for in lovers, no one should become married (pun intended) to an idea of the "ideal mate." All relationships are built on compromise, and everyone is unique and complex. It's impossible to find sweethearts who fit exact molds Commanders may create in their minds.

For these types specifically, it's unrealistic to think that their partners can share all their interests and view things through the same logical lens. Having "enough" in common is often more enriching, as their beloveds can introduce them to new ideas as well. It's also not necessarily wise to judge potential partners based on their perceived intelligence. Knowledge manifests in a variety of ways. Although someone may not be well-versed in philosophy or physics, Commanders shouldn't discount the importance of other forms of intelligence. For example, lovers gifted in psychology can help to balance out some of Commanders' weaknesses by helping them to improve their emotional intelligence. Likewise, potential mates who are incredibly skilled in mechanical or technical projects can provide the skills and know-how to implement ideas that these types can only ponder. The best life partners aren't clones of their mates but, rather, provide balance to their traits and bring out the best in them.

Potential Role Pairings

Exploring the four Role groups and their possible interactions with Commanders in romantic relationships can provide a helpful framework for navigating relationships. However, some caution is warranted. Life is messy and full of hard decisions. People aren't like puzzle pieces that fit other pieces in perfect, predictable ways. Too many variables affect all relationships. Although the information in this section can help Commanders understand their relationships better, nobody can offer exact solutions or predict perfect romantic partners by personality type alone.

Also, traits may live on the surface in obvious ways – but may run as undercurrents. Traits often become subdued over time as the people who possess them adapt and grow. The idea isn't to cram

certain romantic partners into a mold, or to define anything strictly. Rather, the reasonable goal is to discover how traits might influence each unique person within a couple. When it comes to building loving relationships, ongoing personal conversations outdo even the most reliable personality studies.

Commander-Analyst Romantic Relationships

It's often said that "opposites attract," as if human hearts were emotional magnets. If that's true, it's fortunate that no two people are exactly alike, even if they share the same basic personality traits. Relationships between Commanders and other Analysts are hardly like peering into a mirror.

Balanced Commander-Analyst Romantic Relationships

Kindred Minds

When Commanders fall in love with other Analysts, they often feel as though they've finally found someone with whom they can relate. Analysts are about ideas, and Commanders entertain the ideas of their Analyst partners – even if a spirited debate about the quality of those ideas may ensue. In fact, both types often appreciate their partners' shared ability to objectively discuss the merits of ideas, current events, or even the most recent episode of a favorite television show. Such dialogues are immensely important in romantic relationships for these particularly cerebral types, and having partners who share the ability to engage in such conversations (both inside and outside the bedroom) is both valuable and exciting.

Their shared Intuitive and Thinking traits make communication between Commanders and their Analyst sweethearts a simple, erudite affair, while still allowing for plenty of differing opinions. Specific traits, including Introversion, Extraversion, Prospecting, and Judging, influence all Analyst partners' personalities – not to mention the impact of personal experiences and life lessons. Even with their similarities, there remain plenty of nuances and differences to keep these relationships interesting. Commanders might find much in common with Analysts with the Judging or Extraverted traits, and they might find balance with Analysts who possess the Prospecting trait or are Introverted.

Creatively Intellectual

Commanders (and Analysts in general) often put a great deal of emphasis on their intellectual abilities; however, their exceptional ability to engage in imaginative endeavors may be what truly makes them shine. Their ability to combine the creative with the cerebral is impressive. Lovers who share and admire this quality can be hard to come by outside the Analyst Role group. Both Commanders and their Analyst partners are likely to thrive on innovative problem solving, allowing them to settle differences of opinion in particularly interesting and impressive ways.

For example, conflict over who should be responsible for taking out the garbage could result in an exceptionally creative solution for trash removal in general. (Self-emptying, mobile garbage cans, anyone?) Spreadsheets and computer programs that track finances can be sexy when they establish a budget and automatically track spending, earnings, and investments – preventing pesky arguments over financial issues that plague the peons who ignore the beauty of organization. Simply put, being on the same wavelength can allow Commanders and their significant others to focus on what they love best, such as improving their knowledge and brainstorming solutions, without having to worry about the communication issues that may plague romances with other types.

Unbalanced Commander-Analyst Romantic Relationships

Superiority Complex

There's no inherent problem with romantic relationships being more intellectually-based than emotionally-oriented. However, in romances, emotions can surface despite these lovers' discomfort with showing them. Even Commander-Analyst partners, in all their rationality, can still hurt each other emotionally, perhaps by shooting down each other's opinions in front of friends in less-than-sensitive ways.

Commanders have so much confidence in their own ideas that they may slight the Analysts they love by viewing any alternatives their partners present as inferior. Because neither type is likely to approach such situations with regard for each other's feelings or sense of esteem, this can cause chronic feelings of opposition and frustration. A constant sense of opposition doesn't bode well for romantic bonds. In other words, each partner can walk away from such discussions feeling unloved.

Improvement Above All Else

Commanders' and other Analysts' rigorous minds also continually seek areas for improvement, always asking, "How can this be better?" When Commander-Analyst couples believe that everything is subject to debate, they're at risk of continuously overanalyzing their relationships in a misguided attempt to improve them. When they assume their romances are never good enough, or at least never as good as they could be, they can experience perpetual feelings of discontent.

For Commanders, potential improvements may also provide grist for their argument mills. Without some awareness and balance, they tend to spend more time deconstructing, arguing about, and rebuilding their connections to each other than they do simply experiencing them. Constantly discussing and debating both real and perceived relationship issues prevents Commanders and their Analyst partners from living in the moment and appreciating the love they have for one another. Such consistently hard work can be exhausting and corrosive to romance, and it may erode any sense of stability these couples seek.

Rebalancing Commander-Analyst Romantic Relationships

Engaging in Respectful Dialogue

"Give and take" may be a cliché solution to romantic problems, but in a genuine way, Commanders should work on taking their lovers' feelings seriously and providing insight into their own emotions. People with this personality type need to let their well-ordered intellectual universe become penetrable enough to let their partners' (and their own) feelings in and out. Although they may not be fluent in the language of the heart, Commanders and their Analyst partners should still attempt to talk about their emotions.

Perhaps the most important component of such conversations should be an intentional focus on mutual respect and non-judgment. For types who are particularly prone to assigning value to people's words and the emotions they express, it can be difficult to withhold judgment and criticism. Commander lovers who hope to improve communication with their partners and cultivate more loving relationships need to engage in sincere self-reflection to develop the skills for more respectful, considerate dialogue. Understanding the impact that their words and behaviors have on their sweethearts can help Commanders avoid unnecessary conflicts and misunderstandings, as well as provide them with deeper levels of intimacy.

The following exercise can help Commanders become aware of how they communicate with their partners, and then take steps to correct any tendencies toward superiority:

- Take stock: The first step for determining if one has a superiority complex is asking their life partner. Commanders can ask their lovers, in non-defensive and non-judgmental ways, if they've ever felt inferior based on how they treat them.
- Learn the signs of superior behaviors, such as bragging, interrupting, criticizing, and engaging in self-righteous dialogue.
- Consider some trigger words that may accompany superior behavior, such as, "Well, I think/happen to know..." or, "That's dumb/unrealistic/ridiculous" (or any other tag word that indicates a higher level of intelligence than the individual they're talking to).

- Create a "response protocol" they can engage in after a trigger word has been used. For example, if the words, "That's ridiculous," have been uttered, Commanders can plan on adding the phrase, "I apologize, what I meant is that concept doesn't address/answer _____. I don't mean it's less intelligent."

Just being aware of a tendency to engage in less-than-respectful dialogue can be an opportunity for enlightenment for Commanders and their Analyst partners. Learning how to identify such interactions and then deal with the consequent behaviors can reduce conflict and bring these partners closer as well.

Appreciating Instead of Overanalyzing

Even the most logical couples have their flaws, and Commander-Analyst couples can often benefit greatly by getting out of their heads occasionally and living more in the here and now. Simply appreciating their partners instead of analyzing them can strengthen these loving relationships.

People are tremendously complex, and even the most astute couples may never fully understand everything about each other. But that doesn't matter. Although an intellectual understanding of the situation may give Commanders the sense they have a grasp on things, it's likely insufficient by itself if they don't take emotions (both their own and their partners') into consideration.

The strength of romances is that partners enjoy their sweethearts for who they are – not who they could or should be. These rational couples may find it helpful to give themselves permission to live in the moment with their partners rather than analyze their love affairs to death, no matter how uncomfortable or unnatural it might seem initially. For this to happen, Commanders must let go and trust their significant others and their relationships. They may even decide to do something lighthearted instead of pondering heavy things. Experimenting with spontaneity can be the most direct way to confront the tendency to overanalyze relationships. The following exercises can help Commanders practice building emotional connections through spontaneity:

- Plan a surprise date each month with only the day and time agreed to beforehand. Rather than ruminating and discussing endless details, one partner plans an evening or day with only two requirements: the event should bring enjoyment to their significant other, and should hold an element of surprise.
- Just for fun, bring home their partners' favorite takeout, flowers, or board games to play – something they weren't expecting but that they'll certainly appreciate.
- Have a "no screens" rule for at least an hour each day. Taking time to intentionally remove distractions opens opportunities for spontaneous conversations and, ahem, other activities.

When partners take time to just "be" occasionally – and accept one another exactly as they are – they can keep romances healthy and exciting. For types who are prone to living inside their heads, opening up to new adventures and experiencing the "right here, right now" with their significant others can be just the intellectual *and* physical stimulation they need.

Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships

Diplomats' core traits are Intuitive and Feeling. Thanks to the Intuitive part of that combination, Diplomats and Commanders tend to share a visionary view of the world. Unlike most other types, they live a world of ideas and abstractions. The one trait Commanders have that's not shared by any Diplomats is the Thinking trait. While Commanders value decisions and motivations that spring from rationality, Diplomats tend to be driven by more empathetic considerations. When Commanders and Diplomats fall in love, there's a good chance that both the gifts they bring to each other and the potential conflicts in their relationships originate from this difference.

Balanced Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships

A Visionary Pair

As fellow Intuitive types, Commanders and Diplomats share a creative, visionary view of the world. Unlike most other types who focus on what's been done or what is currently happening, these two types have their sights set firmly on a future full of possibilities, as well as opportunities to dream up (and maybe even implement) some of their many ideas.

Conversations between Commanders and their Diplomat partners are likely to be deep discussions focusing on their passions, ideas, and life philosophies. Small talk never stays small for long; even chats about daily activities tie into their hopes, dreams, and plans. In fact, much of the passion between these types can come from communicating their unique visions and exciting ideas. When Commanders find Diplomat sweethearts with enough shared interests and a mutual understanding of what each brings to the table, sparks can fly, and big dreams may just become a reality.

Bringing Out the Best

Both Commanders and Diplomats, with their penchant for living in their heads instead of focusing on the here and now, often find themselves misunderstood by more pragmatic personality types. Their shared Intuitive trait allows for a deep level of connection and understanding that goes beyond social niceties and shared interests. Commanders appreciate their Diplomat darlings' abilities to imagine romance that operates outside of the "expected" social constructs. And Diplomats, with their passion for all things unique and creative, find Commanders to be some of the most ingenious and inventive lovers.

These types can bring out the best in each other, especially when it comes to communication, if they're mature and comfortable with their own identities. Both can be endlessly idealistic and look for partners who will support their off-the-wall (and sometimes spontaneous – hello, Prospecting Diplomats!) ideas. Brainstorming about the future can be both exciting and erotic, if Commanders can reign in their tendency to overanalyze ideas and just let themselves dream for a bit. Similarly, Diplomats can benefit from Commanders' voice of reason

that encourages their daydreams while still providing a much-needed reality check.

Unbalanced Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships

Logic versus Passion

These loving twosomes can face frustrating obstacles if they allow their differing points of view on emotional expressions or romantic gestures to prevent them from appreciating one another. Stoic behavior may be their default mode, but Commanders who refuse to let down the barriers they may have placed around their hearts can struggle to connect with Diplomats who need to *feel* their connections in a more visceral way. Diplomats may not need something as cliché as breakfast in bed or a bouquet of flowers, but they do need to experience tangible expressions of affection to feel loved and appreciated. Even the most adoring and grateful Commanders can struggle to communicate such feelings effectively if they allow their pride to dictate their reactions and behaviors.

Not only can Commanders alienate their Diplomat lovers if they refuse to express their emotions in healthy ways, but they can also do a great disservice to themselves as well. One of the great joys of being human is the ability to experience an emotion as deep and profound as unconditional love. Barriers that they refuse to break down, or even examine, can prevent them from engaging with their partners in ways that create true and lasting intimacy.

Seeking Solutions Over Empathy

People with the Commander personality type are straightforward and often choose hard facts over softer diplomacy, which can be difficult in budding romances. This can cause issues when Diplomats want to vent about problems. Commanders are especially prone to jumping in and offering solutions rather than expressing empathy or compassion. It's part of their *modus operandi* to fix systems that aren't working. Sometimes those systems may be the people they love.

When Diplomats bring problems to their Commander partners, they aren't always looking for action plans. They may simply want someone to listen to them and acknowledge their pain. Diplomats may misinterpret Commanders' sincere wish to help as a cold lack of empathy and perhaps even an absence of caring.

Of course, this works both ways. Diplomats may offer empathy to Commanders who are looking for rational solutions and not "touchy-feely" sentiments. To Commanders, this appears to be frivolous emoting with a lack of real substance. A cycle can begin when Diplomats feel dejected because they don't sense that their Commander sweethearts understand what they're going through, while Commanders remain frustrated by what they see as a foreign injection of emotions into their problems.

Rebalancing Commander-Diplomat Romantic Relationships

Finding Common Ground

Communication and positive perspectives can bring any relationship back to something that's strong and vibrant if given the chance. Maturity plays a role, but to fully succeed, couples need the rudder of intention to steer to a better place. Because of their shared Intuitive trait, these significant others can learn to be open-minded enough to put value in the personality traits of their beloveds. When mature, loving Commanders partner with mature, loving Diplomats, both types learn to appreciate the positives in their partners' ways.

The differences between Commanders and Diplomats regarding emotional expression and romantic gestures can often be worked out in honest, straightforward conversations. Insightful Diplomats grow to understand that Commanders' affections run deep, even if they never fully master outward expressions of love. With maturity, they come to appreciate the love behind any efforts Commanders make. Despite their standards for authenticity, they realize that, although Commanders may not always connect deeply with explicit expressions of love, they're sincere in their desire to please. In turn, Commanders come to appreciate how important these gestures are to their Diplomat

darlings. The following steps can help Commanders to find meaningful ways to engage with their Diplomat partners:

- Learn which romantic sentiments their Diplomat lovers may appreciate, such as Valentine's Day and anniversaries, and then respond accordingly.
- Set an "affection quota" – without, of course, telling their partners. For example, Commanders could hold a hug for 30 seconds at least twice a day. Or, in a similar vein, say, "I love you," at least three times a day.
- Commanders should consider how making symbolic gestures can be incredibly rational in a utilitarian way. As the old saying goes, "Happy spouse, happy house." Make a list of the things such loving gestures might add to their relationships. For example, a kiss when leaving in the morning sets the mood for the day and reassures their sweethearts before a period of absence.

Diplomats likely appreciate the love behind any efforts Commanders make. Despite their standards for authenticity, they realize that, although Commanders may not express love in the same way that they do, they're sincere in their desire to please. And for Commanders, it's likely worth the effort.

Focusing on Empathy Over Answers

Commanders don't readily buy into the idea, but it's true that one can be too honest. Diplomats put significant emphasis on sparing the feelings of others because they believe in the importance of emotional awareness and compassion. Commanders may want to consider the implications of the quote, "Do you want to be right, or do you want to be loved?" Far from being an invitation to behave in phony ways, the quote is more an invitation to frame reality in gentler terms.

Intentional listening is the most valuable tool in the empathy toolbox, as it enables Commanders to understand situations completely before reacting. When their Diplomat partners vent about frustrating situations, Commanders should first listen to get all the information. Then, instead of trying to solve issues, they can simply follow up with reflections that sum up what they've heard. Some specific steps that Commanders can take to practice intentional listening are as follows:

- Repeat back what Diplomat partners say so they know they're being heard. For example, "So, it sounds like you were really upset when your coworkers didn't invite you out for drinks after work." Emphasizing that they truly heard what their partners said is often much more important than judging what they're saying, or trying to fix the problem.
- Adding an empathic statement, such as, "That's really disappointing," is more comforting (and does more to calm the situation) than offering a revengeful solution, like, "You should just ignore them the next time they ask you for help." Though it may not always be obvious why, empathy provides its own solutions to problems, which are often more effective for Diplomats than forced fixes.
- Being aware of their partners' body language is essential. Commanders can get lost in thought, searching for the right solution, and forget the basics of physical connection during communication.
- At some point, once their Diplomats partners have had the opportunity to talk about their feelings, it may then be appropriate for Commanders to ask if their partners would like any suggestions. However, they want to actively resist offering any until they receive the go-ahead.

Everyone likes to be heard. However, it may be important when connecting with others to try to "speak their language." Knowing what others want and need, and then finding ways to give it to them when appropriate, is an important part of building a romance. Not all problems need an immediate solution.

Commander-Sentinel Romantic Relationships

Sentinels, with their Observant trait, aren't nearly as enamored with ideas and visions as their Commander partners might be. Such abstract considerations seem impractical to them. They prefer to pay attention to the present moment and the world around them. Despite their differences, the potential for complementary relationships between the two types is immense. Commanders can bring visionary, creative energy to love affairs with their Sentinel partners. Meanwhile, Sentinels can bring some much-needed practicality and social sensibility to Commanders' otherwise lofty, sometimes self-centered worlds.

Balanced Commander-Sentinel Romantic Relationships

A Deliberate Partnership

Both Commanders and Sentinels respect order and predictability, albeit in different ways. Commanders are interested in more abstract systems as expressions of order, whereas Sentinels find that organizing the tangible is more to their liking. Dating is an excellent example of how their approaches differ. Once Commanders decide to find romantic partners, they view dating as a pressing task – difficult but necessary. They consider what they want in a systematic fashion and use a logical system to develop a list of qualities they expect in potential significant others.

Sentinels also rely on fixed qualities when seeking partners. However, their requirements are unlikely to be determined by a checklist they've developed from pure logic. They rely on experience, gleaning the characteristics they're seeking from traditions they've known, concrete life lessons they've learned, and societal expectations.

Because of their personality traits, both can find a solid foundation by pairing with each other. Although some types prefer a serendipitous approach to love – eyes meeting across the room and that sort of thing – such relations can feel flimsy. In contrast, Commanders and Sentinels who fall in love are likely to have a sense that their romance is very deliberate. Their checklists ensure that all the essential elements are in place, fostering a sense of confidence.

Serious and Stable

Reliability appeals greatly to Sentinels, and Commanders tend to impress them with their serious nature, intelligent demeanor, and intense work ethic. These traits align with Sentinels' desire for stable lives with compatible spouses. Sentinels' organizational abilities, rigorous attention to daily matters, and regard for social conventions and family can help Commanders compensate for any lack in these areas. Commanders solve problems in the lofty reaches of conceptual thought, whereas Sentinels anchor their lives by attending to everyday concerns.

Commander-Sentinel romantic partnerships can be influenced by whether Sentinel partners have the Thinking or Feeling trait. Those with the Thinking trait can be more at home with Commanders' analytical nature. Feeling Sentinels want more emotional support and communication than their Thinking counterparts. Although Feeling Sentinels are distinct from Diplomats, they do share some similarities in their romances with Commanders. However, unlike Diplomats, they're likely to respond to their emotions in more concrete ways, and they often welcome their Commanders partners' compulsion to offer practical fixes to their problems.

Unbalanced Commander-Sentinel Romantic Relationships

Lacking Appreciation

When Intuitive and Observant types meet, clashing over practical matters can be a regular occurrence. The everyday accomplishments that Sentinels handle deftly, and with some pride, can easily fly under the radar of their Commander lovers. Sentinels rarely ask for praise,

but they still enjoy it. When appreciation isn't forthcoming, they may become frustrated, questioning their role in relationships where they feel their lovers take their contributions for granted. Sentinels and Commanders prize loyalty, so this disconnect may not derail their relationships entirely, but lack of recognition creates significant pain for Sentinels.

Nonetheless, Commanders might tolerate dirty dishes in the sink a little longer than their Sentinel sweethearts, especially if they have something else on their minds. It's not overt neglect: Domestic order might be on their radar, but it isn't as high on their list of priorities as it is for Sentinels. Yet, because such everyday matters are so essential to the stability Sentinels value, they can easily become ongoing conflicts in otherwise loving relationships.

Visionary versus Traditional

Commanders are always looking to deconstruct ideas and reassemble them into an improved state. Sentinels prefer the familiar and accept change reluctantly. Commanders can harm their relationships if they treat them as systems to tweak – Sentinels, even those with the Thinking trait, aren't likely to understand or fully appreciate this mindset. They may even view their Commander lovers' penchant for improvement as a threat to the stability they worked so hard to build. Further, if they interpret such endeavors as criticisms of their efforts, Sentinels easily become hurt and defensive. Commanders rebuilding the world into an enhanced place may appear to be no less than destructive to their Sentinel partners.

Finally, Commanders sometimes enjoy considering ideas that might seem controversial to more mainstream Sentinels. If they take their Commander partners too seriously, they might become alarmed or even offended. An assault on conventional thinking, even if it's solely in the realm of the theoretical, tends to jolt tradition-loving Sentinels. In response, Commanders can see Sentinels as unrefined thinkers, and that attitude can come across to Sentinels as condescension. Without mutual respect, diverse approaches and new ideas can cause rifts in Commander-Sentinel love affairs.

Rebalancing Commander-Sentinel Romantic Relationships

Practicing Intentional Appreciation

Commanders can make a special point to express gratitude to the Sentinels they love. It's easy to discover the many ways Sentinels contribute to relationships, beyond utilitarian things like organizing their households or remembering important dates. Sentinels truly want to safeguard the people they love and do what they can to meet as many of their needs as possible.

Although Commanders are independent, stand boldly in their own paradigms, and don't need to hear applause as much as other types, they shouldn't assume this is the same for their Sentinel significant others. Appreciation can be the most cherished gift Commanders can give them. It's reassuring to Sentinels that their partners endorse and value the stability they create and cherish.

The following are some ideas that Commanders can use for showing their Sentinel partners appreciation on a regular basis:

- Leave a thoughtful thank you note in an equally thoughtful place. (Perhaps a "Thank you for washing my underwear!" note on the washing machine, or, "This mirror sure is clean, all the better to see your face" on, well, the mirror.)
- Make it a habit to thank partners for things like making meals, holding open doors, or washing the car.
- Make breakfast in bed, perhaps adding a nice statement about how much they do and how they deserve something nice as a thank you.
- Say, "I love you" regularly.

Even if it feels forced or insincere to acknowledge their partners' contributions in the beginning, Commanders are apt to realize just how much their Sentinel partners do – and just how appreciative they actually are.

Respecting and Embracing Differences

A common mistake among romantic partners is to see their own traits as superior. Commanders and Sentinels are distinct personalities,

and both can be insistent that their way is better. But attempting to remake a significant other into one's own image is rarely successful. Commanders should understand that Sentinels aren't always comfortable with their big ideas and constant attempts to improve things. Without such awareness, trying to force them to "get it" can become a futile obsession.

Likewise, Sentinels may never quite domesticate their Commander lovers as much as they would like. In fact, Commanders are one of the types least likely to be persuaded by others, and the most liable to see compromise as a form of failure. Family traditions may never capture their hearts, and they're often distracted from the conventional aspects of life that are so important to Sentinels. Here are some ways they can embrace and respect their Sentinel darlings for who they are:

- Avoid partner "makeovers." It's a fool's errand to commit to another with the intention of changing them. An appropriate balance would involve each lover *voluntarily* dedicating themselves to their own growth, with an openness to learn from each other.
- Invest time in finding out what each type values. Commanders should avoid assuming they know what their Sentinel lovers hold dear. There may be more depth and substance there than what Commanders may suspect.
- Avoid overanalyzing motives. Sometimes the most obvious reason for something is the only relevant reason. Someone who insists on a meticulous house may not be a control freak, just someone who likes a clean house.
- Remember the original reasons for falling in love – those characteristics probably haven't changed. The disconnect is more likely about shifting expectations.

It's helpful to remember that relationships are often complementary, even between similar types. Thinking of significant others as gifts that enhance, rather than obstacles to overcome, goes a long way in romance, especially when partners have diverse characteristics.

Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Commander-Explorer couples are Intuitive-Observant pairs with a typical divide between visionaries and hands-on "doers." Explorers live almost entirely in the present and seek out the new and the exciting. They're curious about everything – except long-winded discussions revolving around abstractions and ideas (some of Commanders' favorite things). But despite their differences, Commanders and Explorers in love can bring much to each other's lives.

Balanced Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Vision and Pragmatism

Both Commanders and Explorers enjoy solving things, but the former tend to ponder theoretical puzzles, whereas the latter think on their feet, unraveling real-time problems. Commanders often admire Explorers' love for specific challenges, such as mastering a musical instrument or craft. Explorers are undoubtedly impressed by the ease with which many Commanders can unravel even the most complex puzzles or problems. Despite their different styles, both types share some measure of commonality in their desire to find solutions that might easily overlap or complement each other.

On a first date, if Commanders can connect the ideas they love to play with to something practical and immediately useful, they'll impress their Explorer dates. Commanders who talk about the benefits of learning computer code and how it can be used to develop software to run a 3D printing program, for example, might appeal to Explorers' appreciation of practical, useful skills. If Commanders veer off and begin talking

about something like hypothetical social effects of artificial intelligence, however, Explorers tend to be quick to bring them back to the present and more down-to-earth topics.

Open-Minded Meets Spontaneous

Explorers' spontaneity and practicality may actually attract Commanders. Although they have adventurous imaginations, they aren't nearly as comfortable in novel real-time situations as Explorers are. As a counterbalance to their own serious nature, they can indulge in their Explorer partners' freer, fun-loving attitudes. Both Commanders and Explorers think on their feet in different ways. If they can tap into this in service of their love for each other, they can find rich, satisfying romances together. At the same time, both types value their independence a great deal and won't hesitate to allow their partners the same freedom and flexibility they so desire. Nobody would accuse Commander-Explorer couples of smothering each other.

In committed relationships, these types both appreciate each other's disregard for social conventions. They welcome the space they grant each other when Commanders dive deep into their latest interests and Explorers become so obsessed with their projects they seem almost entirely detached from their home lives. Explorers virtually disappearing on occasion could work out well for independent Commanders, giving them ample time to discover their worlds in their own very distinct ways.

Unbalanced Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Mind Over Matter – For Better or Worse

Their often-blatant bias for intellectual competence over physical abilities (or any other skills for that matter) can cause significant friction in Commander-Explorer love affairs. Explorers are likely to be offended by the suggestion that their Commander beloveds' mental abilities are superior to either their own or the myriad other skills and talents they may have. Additionally, Commanders are apt to miss out on some of the truly unique, inspiring aspects of their partners' personalities if they discount their plethora of artistic, technical, and social skills.

Explorers, on the other hand, may find themselves impatient with Commanders' obsession with presenting theories while, at times, neglecting reality. Although Commanders may seem immune to criticism, the truth is they often feel it deeply. Explorers who dismiss their significant others as stodgy, intellectually elitist, impractical, or boring are committing a sort of reverse snobbery that can be just as hurtful. None of this is fertile soil for growing romantic relationships.

Out of Sync

Commanders and Explorers have characteristics in common – their love of solving real-life riddles, for example. But they differ in how they focus their attention on such puzzles and other matters. When Commanders face a problem, they prefer to spend a lengthy amount of time methodically deconstructing and then rebuilding it, looking for as many viable solutions as possible so they can commit to the best one. Explorers are as persistent as the adrenaline charge they get from working on a specific challenge. Once it becomes too repetitive or feels routine – and once a reasonable amount of excitement evaporates – Explorers are off looking for the next fascination. Novelty is the draw for them, and changing focus is typical.

Commanders' need for meticulous deliberation can annoy impatient Explorers, who prefer to act first and think later. Romance can be tricky to navigate when one type is more focused on acting intentionally and the other is more interested in being spontaneous. Such differences can put these lovers on differing natural rhythms for decision making, and the features they loved so much in each other at first can become a tiresome load when they progress into something relentless.

Rebalancing Commander-Explorer Romantic Relationships

Up to the Challenge

Future-focused Commanders have a strong inclination toward self-improvement. If they remember that romances are about human needs and desires, this quality can hold power in relationships. If they remember that love involves accepting each other and cherishing

each other's gifts, talents, and skills as much as it does growth, this can be their greatest tool. Contentment and emotional fulfillment with their Explorer partners can co-exist with Commanders' preference for rationality and systemic improvement, but only if they strive to create a marriage between their cerebral preferences and matters of the heart.

Love isn't about the right skills, nor the right words. It's about extending one's self to merge on some level with another while holding tight to one's unique identity. Commanders have what it takes to meet challenges and develop wonderful romances based on a combination of their unique styles. Blending their shared desire to improve themselves with their courage to take on challenging tasks can serve them well when they seek to improve their relationships with their Explorer partners. Here are some specific steps that Commanders can take to develop a greater appreciation for what their Explorer sweethearts bring to the table:

- Meet partners in the present. It's easy to dream about what romances could be, but it's more satisfying to live in the moment and appreciate what relationships truly *are*. Taking regular walks together, chatting about the day, or texting them a daily expression of gratitude ("I'm grateful you took out the trash this morning," or, "I'm grateful for the nice evening we had last night!") are just a few ways to acknowledge what lovers bring to their relationships.
- Stop trying to change partners. He may never be into reading about Stephen Hawking, and she may have no desire to discuss the pros and cons of cryptocurrency, but that doesn't make them less intelligent or informed. Instead of trying to get Explorers to embrace their passions, Commanders should spend time engaging with them about some of theirs.
- Make a gratitude list. List at least five things that Explorer partners are good at, that they're admired for, or that just makes people smile. This is something that can be done together, perhaps over supper each evening, or in a more private platform like a journal.

Commanders who have spent much of their relationships focusing on what their partners lack and what their relationships need to be better can learn to see what's truly great about what they have.

Self-improvement should focus not just on what Commanders can do to improve themselves in the future, but how they can appreciate their lives, and their loving relationships, right *now*.

Adopting Alternative Rhythms

Adaptation is a requirement in life and, no matter the personality type, it's required for success. This doesn't mean people shouldn't be true to themselves and play to their strengths. For Commander and Explorer couples, adaptation often involves accepting their beloveds' different foci and life rhythms. It doesn't necessarily mean keeping pace with each other – although Commanders sharing their deliberative natures and Explorers their spontaneous styles can be beneficial. It more often means tolerating and even appreciating each other's differences.

Commanders who want to understand the style of Explorers who have stolen their hearts might try joining in on their adventures occasionally. Doing so provides many advantages; the most relevant to romance involves understanding and connecting more intimately with their Explorer lovers. But there are other bonuses to embracing a different style occasionally.

Henry Miller wrote, "All growth is a leap in the dark, a spontaneous, unpremeditated act without the benefit of experience." Whether it is or not, sometimes Commanders must allow life to unfold more on its own and in a less controlled fashion if they're to experience it more fully. Sharing in their significant others' hunger for the fresh and novel can stimulate that appetite in themselves. A role-reversal that has Commanders initiating what Explorers might normally suggest can pump more enthusiasm into romantic relationships stuck on their differences. Consider the following:

- Look for events Explorer partners might like. Finding out what that is might take some time and objective observation. When choosing, keep the focus on Explorers' preferences.
- Set up a "surprise" date based on one of those events.
- Keep an open mind and a willing attitude – it can make almost anything pleasant and even enjoyable.

Commanders, perhaps a little more than most, cling tightly to their own styles. When these pairs can exchange some of their preferences, both types are treated to a bigger world. But even more importantly, such sharing can pull Commander-Explorer couples with such different approaches to life closer together.

Conclusion

When Commanders are in love, it isn't likely to be the stuff of poets and sonnets. Compared with what's portrayed in popular media, their love lives might appear tepid at the surface. This proves the adage about looks being deceiving. Just because romances don't exude showy emotions doesn't mean intense bonds aren't forming. All relationships take work and attention. With a little focus and prioritization, Commanders can offer profound devotion and meaningful love.

Being comfortable with what it means to be "Commanders in love" is likely to be a significant hurdle for these types. But once they jump it, their confidence gets stronger. They need not look like anyone else or follow the scripts of conventional love stories to have wonderful romances, custom-made for them and their lovers. The rarest version of any collectible is the most valuable – an idea worth embracing when Commanders pursue romance.

Friendships

Driven and intense, Commanders seek friendships that offer mental engagement, big ideas, and a sturdy match for their strong personalities. In friendship, Commanders want intellectual counterparts who understand their goals and keep up with their ambitions. They especially enjoy friends with whom they can be direct and unfiltered, as hand-holding and tact aren't their specialties.

Commanders' propensity for sarcasm, humor, and stark opinions aren't for those who struggle to read between the lines, nor for the faint of heart. But for those who can handle it, they offer exciting friendships full of energy and purpose, creating space for everyone to grow and evolve.

Commander chums can expect vivid conversations, bold ideas, and spirited debates, as well as true respect. Beneath their unvarnished candor, these types hold their friends in high esteem – after all, they hold rigorous standards for the people in their lives, so the very existence of their friendships are declarations of respect. Provided they practice balanced ways of treating others, Commanders can build a circle of friends who enjoy their company and accept them just as they are.

The Leading Edge

To advance on their path of personal growth, Commanders must deepen their social relationships and their understanding of others. Perhaps the most important skill for people with this personality type is emotional awareness, which improves trust and communication in their relationships and ultimately leads to social advancement. Yes,

Commanders can accomplish much with their strong minds, ironclad will, and powerful ideas – but good friends can help carry them even further.

Beyond external accomplishments, friendships enrich Commanders' lives on an internal level. Beneath their bravado and independence, they can still suffer from feelings of disconnection or loneliness, and like anyone, they benefit from emotional support. If they learn to relax and accept the joy of camaraderie, their lives can take on new dimensions.

Exacting Requirements

Commanders aren't easy to impress. Although they ignore many traditional rules of social conduct, they have their own high expectations of others. Therefore, their friendship isn't to be taken lightly. When they do meet others who match their requirements, they feel respect and appreciation they can't always express in words.

Sadly, their friends might not be able to feel their esteem. Commanders expect to stay on good terms with their pals without a great deal of maintenance. Common gestures of friendship – such as sending birthday cards, offering a shoulder to cry on, or simply checking in with someone – aren't their forte. This doesn't reflect a lack of affection or an unwillingness to expend effort on their relationships, however. These types pride themselves on being available to their friends whenever they're needed, particularly if they can offer concrete support or advice. If friends are needed to help bail others out of trouble, Commanders are a good bet.

Pointed Honesty

Some friends build each other up with ego-stroking, but Commanders unabashedly share their opinions – without necessarily considering the resulting emotional impact. Such blunt behavior is rarely intended to be mean. These types challenge their friends to improve just as they challenge themselves, offering what they see as constructive observations. In an age of gossip, false social veneers, and the worship of appearances, their sharp, insightful honesty can be refreshing, if abrasive.

Their forthrightness means that Commanders have little taste for emotional games. They prefer to fight their battles with facts, not emotional manipulation. Although they aren't the gentlest of communicators, their sincerity means that their friends can trust what they say – whether it's positive or negative. If they learn to respect their chums' emotional needs as much as they respect their own opinions, Commanders can foster friendships of mutual trust and support.

Commanders and Friends from Other Roles

At certain stages of their lives, Commanders might be tempted to prioritize personal achievement over their relationships. Once they recognize the value of human connection, however, they're motivated to enhance their social abilities and deepen their connections – which are both tall orders. Fortunately, Commanders have the tools to meet the challenge. When they decide to master something, little can stop them.

Let's look at some patterns that emerge in Commanders' friendships with people from all four Role groups, focusing on strategies they can use to create and sustain beneficial, fair, and fulfilling friendships.

Commander-Analyst Friendships

At times, Commanders can feel misaligned with the world. Everywhere they turn, they spot people making irrational decisions, settling for the status quo, and being fake to be likable or impressive. Fortunately, making friends with other Analysts can help them feel less alone in their values of rationality, progress, and authenticity. When they befriend other Analysts, Commanders often feel energized yet comfortable, delighting in the company of those who understand and accept them.

Balanced Commander-Analyst Friendships

Compatible Creativity

Other Analysts are usually a quick fit for Commanders, are they share a passion for new ideas, knowledge, and unconventional thought. Such camaraderie tends to be based more on intellectual engagement rather than social or emotional support, which is often how Commanders like it. They may have grown accustomed to feeling frustrated or bored with the world's common and limited ways, and friendships with other Analysts can be invigorating breaths of fresh air.

That air comes in handy because these friends never run out of things to talk – or argue – about. Commanders are full of analyses, questions, and ideas, and other Analysts are likely to keep pace and properly challenge them. These friends love bouncing ideas back and forth, dissecting each other's ideas piece by piece, an oddly enjoyable process. There's pleasant competition in these alliances, with each challenging the other to establish a stronger foundation for their thoughts.

Free to Be

Even independent-minded Commanders can feel the pressure to conform. Every day, advertisements and social media carpet-bomb audiences with artfully curated images of what it means to be successful, happy, or desirable. Spending time with Analyst friends – who share a healthy disrespect for societal expectations – reassures Commanders that they're free to be themselves.

Other Analyst types may challenge them with hard-hitting questions, but at their core, they deeply respect and appreciate their friends for who they are. As a result, time spent with Analysts can help Commanders feel empowered to be authentic and pursue their interests and curiosity with little or no inhibition – whether they're fascinated by sound engineering, avian migration, or New York history. In turn, Commanders who unabashedly pursue their interests, embrace their quirks, and prioritize their values can inspire their Analyst pals to do the same.

Unbalanced Commander-Analyst Friendships

Impatience

Commanders have little tolerance for ineffectiveness, procrastination, or indecision, and their tendency to see broken systems everywhere creates a strong pull to fix things. As a result, they can lose patience with friends who put off taking positive action in their lives. If friends complain about their jobs without applying for new ones, ever-candid Commanders won't hesitate to call them out on it.

This can spark tension with other Analyst types – Debaters and Logicians in particular – who might discuss ideas or solutions without readily acting on them. Although Commanders may hope they're inspiring their friends to finally do something by pointing out their inaction, the approach backfires if they come on too strong. At first, their friends may feel defensive, annoyed, or even stifled. Over time, they might pull away from Commanders altogether, not wanting to deal with their judgment or their impatience.

Problems also arise when Commanders' Extraversion clashes with the socially reserved style of Architects and Logicians. Commanders may have a hard time drawing their Introverted friends out in public; in response, they might push harder, urging their friends toward bolder action. If Commanders can't muster tolerance for their friends' limits, they can become critical, potentially causing offense and leading Introverts to withdraw even further. Overall, their forceful manner runs the risk of steamrolling or provoking their Analyst friends, who can themselves be quite reactive. In the absence of respectful communication, Commander-Analyst friendships won't thrive.

Butting Heads

Even like minds don't always see eye to eye, and when Commanders and their Analyst friends disagree on core views, spectacular sparks can fly. Commanders' Judging trait makes them stubborn, and they may find themselves at odds with other Analysts. Commanders, always ready for a mental duel, may not mind the tension, but when a good friend's personal views are the topic, arguing with every ounce of wit and energy can be a mistake.

For Commander-Analyst friends, battling each other's ideas can easily turn from stimulating to frustrating, testing established friendships or causing new attachments to falter. Commanders often can't temper their compulsion to *win*, which can be a problem with Analyst friends, who tend to have their own strong opinions. If they choose personal power over friendly compromise, Commanders may conclude that some friends simply can't handle the "truth."

Rebalancing Commander-Analyst Friendships

Don't Push – Inspire

Here's a rational argument against pushing friends to act: It rarely works. No one wants to feel criticized or nagged, and even rational-minded Analysts may dig in their heels when Commanders point out how they're failing to live out their ideas. This often befuddles Commanders, whose "pestering" is generally motivated by a sincere desire to help.

So, how can Commanders manage friendships with people who aren't as decisive as they are? The first step is to observe and note their current behavior. Commanders may be surprised to realize how often they bring up their friends' areas of inaction, such as looking for new jobs or ending relationships that aren't working. The second step is to remember that nobody puts off action without a reason. Either they're encountering resistance – perhaps due to insecurity, uncertainty, or other obligations – or they aren't that interested in making a change – it's idle musing. There's nothing inherently wrong with either state. In fact, even most Commanders have experienced inaction at one point or another in their lives. The third step is to recognize that, if someone is truly struggling to act, showing support usually works better than badgering or shaming them.

To support their friends who are putting off an important change, Commanders can try the following exercise:

- For these types, it's often easier to spot inconsistencies in other people's behavior than in their own. Before commenting on Analyst friends' choices (or lack thereof), pausing to consider whether they're

projecting any of their own issues might be revealing. For example, perhaps they're fixating on their friend's job dissatisfaction rather than facing up to their own.

- Listen carefully, and ask questions before offering advice: "What do you think is holding you back?" "What would be a realistic first step for you to take?"
- Commanders want to help in concrete ways, which is a gift – provided their friends are ready for it. Make a specific offer to help only after listening to the answers in the previous step, and ensure that the offer aligns with the friend's vision for next steps. In other words, if someone thinks a realistic first step is to update their resume, don't offer to get them an interview with the CEO of a company.
- Don't impose a deadline on the offer of assistance. Saying, "I'm here to help when you're ready," can go a long way.
- When in doubt, Commanders can inspire their friends simply by making needed changes in their own lives – whether asking for a promotion, learning a new skill, or signing up for a 5K run. That way, friends will know where to turn when they need inspiration, guidance, or support in taking charge.

Commanders might want to provide their friends with hard-nosed "reality checks," but even with other Analysts, the approach usually backfires. By supporting rather than pushing friends who aren't acting, Commanders can honor their own desire to help without diminishing their pals' self-esteem or unduly straining their relationships.

Prove It Together

One excellent way for Commanders and their Analyst friends to relieve mental friction with each other is to step outside the intellectual realm. Debating what's "right" is tiring. These friends can take a break from seeking complex truths by instead sharing the simple joys of fun-finding rather than fact-finding. Planning hands-on activities together is a great alternative to talkative mind-fests, as real-world experiences can wash tension away. Bike rides, basketball games, and barbecues are just a few examples of how these friends might escape whirling mental potentials and have refreshing fun in the moment.

When disagreements do arise, Commanders and their Analyst friends can break out of circular or hypothetical arguments by embarking on hands-on experiments together. After all, if they collaborate on attempts to find the truth and bring ideas into reality, both gain wisdom and perspective. Commanders love to learn, and chasing data with friends can be doubly enjoyable, by not only providing useful knowledge but also building stronger friendships through cooperation. Here's how they can get started:

- First, build the skill of recognizing when a debate leaves friendly terrain and becomes unproductive or tedious. Some indicators of such a shift are muscular tension, raised voices, rolled eyes, criticism, contempt, or repeated statements.
- When a red flag arises, steer the discussion toward experiments that could test the idea in question.
- Rather than testing competing hypotheses, choose an approach that's cooperative. Look for ways to make the project concrete, and foster hands-on creation, perhaps by building something or creating a simulation.
- Afterward, review and discuss the results with the goal of discovering the truth, not proving each other wrong.

If such measures prove ineffective, a cordial "agree to disagree" approach may be the only fair solution. It's important for Commanders and other Analysts to recognize that pluralistic objectivity is a mark of an evolved intellect. Basic tolerance may be required between strong-minded, intelligent friends, and it's often the only thing that allows intellectually nourishing friendships to flourish despite differences.

Commander-Diplomat Friendships

Commanders and Diplomats often share a rapid connection because they recognize in each other the ability to see beyond the superficial into deep, mysterious dimensions. Their main difference is that Diplomats tend to view the world in terms of harmonious cooperation and hopeful ideals, whereas Commanders are more likely to coolly consider possibility tempered with probability. The difference is unlikely to derail their connection, however, and can even inspire new understanding for both.

Balanced Commander-Diplomat Friendships

Keeping It Fresh

Commanders and Diplomats often enjoy an immediate sense of kinship, given their insightfulness and their shared passion for fresh ideas. In fact, Diplomats often tick all the boxes on Commanders' checklist for the "ideal friend." Yet they can also help break down Commanders' tendency to reduce people into checklists and categories, showing them the joy in diversity and inspiring them to appreciate people as they are.

Commanders can learn from their Diplomat friends that even the most unassuming people can be exciting, profound, and intelligent. This mindset expands their worldview and reveals what everyone around them has to offer, from strangers sitting next to them on the train to the people they encounter every day. Spotting such potential is Diplomats' specialty; for Commanders, spending time with them can be eye-opening.

Although Commanders excel at dispassionate efficiency, they often marvel at Diplomats' ability to bring people together for the greatest possible outcome. If these chums use their strengths in tandem, applying rational ideas to high ideals, they become a mighty force for the common good – and for mutual growth. Overall, Commanders' relationships with Diplomats run deep, allowing both to explore new terrain.

Balancing Each Other

On a more personal level, Commanders can exchange some truly significant qualities back and forth with their Diplomat friends. Commanders may offer reasoned thinking that accommodates Diplomats' idealism and creativity, helping their friends focus their passionate energy. From Diplomats, Commanders can gain revelatory dimensions of emotional insight, helping them explore the complex mysteries of human interactions – and themselves. These comrades have the potential to lead each other to tremendous personal growth.

Efficiency without compassion is difficult and lonely. Compassion without rational discipline meanders from one unbridled feeling to another. Friends who balance each other in those areas are valuable companions, so there's much potential in friendships that emerge between Commanders and Diplomats.

Unbalanced Commander-Diplomat Friendships

"Excuse Me?"

Generally staunch in their views, Commanders might see Diplomats as relatively persuadable or acquiescent. However, that isn't necessarily true. Diplomats may shy away from disagreements, but this doesn't mean they'll yield to the opinions of others. In fact, they can have strongly held ideals and principles – especially Judging Diplomats.

If Commanders alienate their Diplomat friends by harshly disagreeing with or criticizing something important to them, the resulting rift may be deep and difficult to repair. Some Diplomats may react strongly even to constructive criticism or well-intended feedback. In response, Commanders might push harder, trying to prove the rationality or

"rightness" of their perspective. The result is often resentment and disappointment on both sides.

All the Feels

Commanders often think of strong emotional expression as incompatible with truth, logic, or accomplishment – in other words, something to be "dealt with" rather than honored and integrated into their day-to-day lives. For their Diplomat friends, who consider emotional transparency a critical way of connecting with others, such an attitude can come across as hostile and distant. When Diplomats try to unburden themselves emotionally, Commanders may react awkwardly, change the subject, or offer advice rather than sympathy. Even when they truly want to help their upset friends, Commanders can struggle to find words of support.

Such differences can profoundly affect Commander-Diplomat friendships. Sensitive Diplomats might feel judged or dismissed, which may lead them to pull away. On the other hand, Commanders might feel exhausted after spending time with their emotionally expressive friends, eventually retreating from what they perceive as uncontrolled chaos.

Rebalancing Commander-Diplomat Friendships

Preventing "Foot-in-Mouth Disease"

Commanders may be surprised to discover just how much their unflinching honesty can wound sensitive Diplomats, who easily take criticism and disagreement personally. Fortunately, if they take a few simple precautions when voicing their opinions, their incisiveness can be an asset to their friendships.

Instead of indulging in the ego-stroking that some people use to form bonds, Commanders offer directness as an expression of respect. Because it comes from a place of integrity and authenticity, their directness can become endearing to their friends – yes, even Diplomats. By speaking their minds carefully and respectfully, Commanders can ensure that their ideas and feedback help their Diplomat pals, rather than trigger defensiveness or hurt feelings.

So, how can Commanders bring the benefits of their directness to their friendships without alienating Diplomats? It's easier not to say something in the first place than to take it back, so Commanders do well to put themselves through the following mental hurdles before speaking.

- Consider whether there's any real benefit to correcting or criticizing friends at this point. Are they in a position to be receptive to feedback right now, or are they emotionally distressed or upset? If it's the latter, speaking up at this time would likely backfire.
- Resist the temptation to interrupt friends to offer an opinion. Interrupting someone might seem like a time-saving measure – especially if they're just going on and on – but it puts them on the defensive, making the conversation less productive overall.
- Know when to back off giving advice and feedback. For example, never offer criticism or hard-to-swallow opinions to those in emotional distress. Signs of emotional distress include an especially fast or slow pace of speaking, crossed arms or a hunched posture, and – of course – crying.
- When in doubt, before stepping in, ask, "Do you mind if I offer my perspective?" Remember that Diplomats might find it difficult to say no outright, so if they show reluctance, hold off until a few hours – or days – later.

Commanders' directness can be a gift, but in some instances, discretion is the better part of valor. Fortunately, people with this personality type are willing to think before they speak, which prevents "foot-in-mouth disease." By running through the points above before sharing criticism or feedback with their Diplomat friends, Commanders can save their insights for times when their contributions can truly be beneficial.

Validation + Support + Encouragement

Commanders don't love talking about feelings – and in many situations, that's perfectly fine. That said, they can short-change their friendships, particularly with Diplomats, if they shut down every conversation involving emotions. Diplomats look to such discussions as opportunities to express their true, authentic selves, so relationships feel shallow to them if they can't emotionally unburden themselves when necessary.

As they mature and become more attuned to others' needs, Commanders recognize that some people struggle in relationships that are the emotional equivalent of brick walls. At times, friendships with Diplomats require validation, support, and encouragement. Fortunately, Commanders are perfectly capable of learning effective ways to comfort their Diplomat friends who are going through tough times – even if it doesn't always feel easy or comfortable.

Here's how Commanders can meet Diplomats' emotional needs while staying true to themselves:

- Use the formula: emotional engagement = validation + support + encouragement.
- Start with *validation*, which means demonstrating awareness and understanding of what others are experiencing. Listen carefully. Take care not to speak more than those who are upset, not to interrupt them, and not to unnecessarily discredit what they're saying.
    - Remember: Everyone is entitled to their experiences, and feelings are valid, even if they don't seem helpful or rational. To express validation, simply reiterate the emotions others are expressing, without judgment or minimization. For example: "It sounds like you've had a really tough time of it," or, "It sounds like you're really hurt."
- Progress to *support*, which can be as simple as saying, "I'm here for you." Even if it feels awkward to say it (or less effective than offering advice), Diplomats benefit immensely from such outward expressions.
- End with *encouragement*, which is an unconditional offering of future support – in other words, "When you want to make a change, I will help you – if you want my help."

Even if Commanders feel uncomfortable or overwhelmed in such conversations, Diplomats sense their good intentions. By following the formula of validation + support + encouragement, Commanders can be there for their friends in the way Diplomats crave.

Commander-Sentinel Friendships

Commanders may find that Sentinels complement them very well as friends. Sentinels can help ground Commanders, offering the tenacity, consistency, and pragmatism that they tend to crave in their relationships. In return, Commanders may enjoy the opportunity to expand Sentinels' awareness beyond the mastery of pragmatic, tangible concerns, helping them develop their own creativity and imagination.

Balanced Commander-Sentinel Friendships

A Solid Foundation

Commanders and Sentinels might seem like an odd match, given Commanders' thirst for innovation and Sentinels' respect for tradition and protocol. But beneath the surface, the two types share similar desires for their friendships. Both value loyalty and consistency, and although Commanders may not be quite as grounded as most Sentinels, well-rounded Sentinels appreciate the other traits that Commanders offer – for example, their willingness to help friends in concrete ways.

Their similarities create a solid foundation for friendship, with each trusting the other to have their back. Commanders know that Sentinels will show up for them, whether by helping them with a move to a new apartment or encouraging them to focus on what they can do in the moment when they feel overwhelmed. In return, Sentinels appreciate that Commanders take the time to understand things and act with forethought, often serving as stabilizing, foundational influences for the people who matter to them. These chums can stand the test of time, holding strong through the life changes and time pressures that allow so many other friends to drift apart.

Follow-Through

In a world that can seem like all talk and no follow-through, Commanders and Sentinels recognize each other as take-charge kindred spirits. This creates an important baseline of respect in their alliance, which is important, as both Commanders and Sentinels chafe at spending time around people who fall short of their standards. For Commanders, close Sentinel friendships can be a refuge from all the people in their lives who seem flaky or inconsistent.

Thanks to their shared, results-driven mindset, Commanders and Sentinels follow through on their plans to spend time together. They don't swap the idle line, "We should hang out sometime," which characterizes many anemic friendships. As a result, they share experiences and bond in ways that make sense to them, actively sustaining and developing their relationships instead of simply paying them lip service.

Unbalanced Commander-Sentinel Friendships

Different Perspectives and Priorities

Connections between Commanders and Sentinels often emerge due to circumstance – for example, if they're coworkers or roommates. In such environments, Commanders are likely to witness Sentinels' pragmatic effectiveness, which garners their respect.

That said, Commanders may not always understand what seem like obvious limits in others' approach to life. For one thing, Commanders love to disrupt the status quo and aim for risky, ambitious goals, but Sentinels can be alarmed by the prospect of jetting off on seemingly less secure paths – particularly when current issues need hands-on work. Commanders don't always understand Sentinels' respect for conventional expectations, nor their lack of enthusiasm for theorizing. These disconnects can be significant initial challenges to friendships between the two types.

Clashing Values

Commanders tend to be more irreverent and skeptical than tradition-minded Sentinels, which can create tension between them, particularly

because these friends may both have mild (or not-so-mild) disdain for those who don't see things their way. In general, Commanders love to question the institutions that many Sentinels hold dear, from religion to government to social norms and conventions. Alas, many Sentinels are (understandably) resistant when others try to upend their worldview or negate their values.

The dynamic plays out in an obvious way when Commanders point out logical inconsistencies that underpin Sentinels' values and beliefs. Although they're just trying to be accurate, they can damage their relationships if their Sentinel friends feel attacked, talked down to, or belittled.

The dynamic can also harm friendships in less obvious ways. For example, Commanders might try to push their Sentinel friends to have less "conventional" dreams: "Why settle for 2.2 kids, a 9-to-5 job, and a white picket fence when you could be an astronaut/entrepreneur/CEO?" However well intended, such comments unfairly imply that Sentinels' aspirations aren't good enough, which can leave them feeling defensive or unsupported. Commanders can indeed broaden Sentinels' horizons, but they can do so with respect for Sentinels' existing values and priorities. Otherwise, they risk pushing away their Sentinel friends.

Rebalancing Commander-Sentinel Friendships

Befriending Sentinels

In the early stages of their acquaintanceship, Commanders might conclude that Sentinels won't fit the bill, particularly if Sentinels don't seem receptive to Commanders' theoretical or disruptive style of thinking and conversing. Unfortunately, that mindset closes Commanders off from rewarding social interactions – including friendships – with a significant portion of the population. It also keeps them in an echo chamber, where they aren't challenged by alternative points of view or different personalities, even when those alternate perspectives reflect societal norms.

Fortunately, Commanders don't need to be coddled, and they don't expect constant validation. In addition, they see the utility of diverse

friendships. They know that, like everyone, they have weaknesses, and they're rational enough to recognize that they can benefit from friends whose strengths lie in other areas. As a result, Commanders who want to feel more grounded in their home lives or their communities may wish to seek out friendships with Sentinels, who excel in those areas.

Commanders can enhance their open-mindedness – and get to know Sentinels on a deeper level – by doing the following:

- When talking with Sentinel acquaintances, take the position of an interviewer, steering the conversation from small talk to things that truly matter to Sentinels. Seek out ways their interests and perspectives might harmonize (rather than conflict) with Commanders' interest in innovation. For example, it may come to light that Sentinel friends have addressed pressing needs by spearheading initiatives to bring a community together, ensure efficiency, or automate processes.
- Look for common ground – for example, a focus on optimal outcomes. Ask Sentinels what they hope to achieve through their work or other activities. Chances are that they'll have gratifyingly specific answers.
- Even though they're a significant portion of the population, Sentinels can be outsiders or underdogs – and many Commanders can relate. If the Sentinels in question seem relatively comfortable and self-assured, turn the conversation toward times they've upheld their values despite opposition or persevered despite difficulties. Sentinels don't often call attention to their determination, but they enjoy speaking about it when given the opportunity, and it's a trait that Commanders generally find admirable.

Of course, not every Sentinel can be a match for every Commander – and that's perfectly all right. That's the case with people from any other Role group. However, by using the suggested conversational techniques, Commanders can break through superficial differences, find common ground, and identify Sentinels who can become great friends.

R-E-S-P-E-C-T

Diverse friendships are a gift, in part because they make Commanders question themselves. Do their choices make them feel fulfilled and

happy, or would they be better off if they tried a different way of living? Is their definition of a "good life" really the best? Commanders generally recognize the utility of confronting and re-assessing their assumptions, and they may appreciate how interactions with Sentinel friends force them to do so.

Even if they don't directly address their differences, the two types can enjoy surprisingly pleasurable friendships based on respect and mutuality. It's important to remember that each friendship serves different needs in our lives, and not every friend must fulfill every need. Sentinels might not "get" Commanders' unconventional manners and aspirations, and they might not like breaking with convention in ways that make Commanders' hearts beat faster. However, that doesn't diminish the fact that these friends can have fun going to the movies together or grabbing a cup of coffee. Whatever their differences, they can still enjoy each other's company and offer practical, well-intended support when it's needed.

Expecting all rewarding relationships to be founded on perfect compatibility is an impossible ideal. Recognizing that can lighten Commanders' loads and brighten their friendships. To reframe their attitude accordingly, Commanders can try the following steps:

- Pay attention to what types of activities are especially enjoyable with Sentinel friends.
- Express appreciation for those moments out loud. It can be as simple as, "I'm glad we were able to see that movie together," or, "Thanks for following up about getting dinner together. I'm glad we made it happen."
- Note feelings before and after spending time with Sentinel friends, and express gratitude for any positive shifts: "My mind was all over the place earlier today, and now I'm feeling a lot less stressed. Thanks for that."

Sentinels are touched by moments of appreciation, and voicing such thoughts aloud reminds Commanders of the strengths of their particular brand of friendship.

Commander-Explorer Friendships

Commander-Explorer friendships have lots of potential, especially if they share common interests. Commanders may struggle to let go of compulsive analyses and simply have fun, but they can look to Explorer chums to help them approach the world with enthusiasm and unworried curiosity. On the other hand, Commanders can help Explorers see their deeper potential and consider the consequences of their actions. Setting sail is a grand adventure, but they need someone beside them who knows how to navigate; these two can be excellent partners in discovery.

Balanced Commander-Explorer Friendships

Appreciating Diverse Strengths

In truly fulfilling friendships, Commanders appreciate that their friends' strengths differ from their own, admiring their unique and impressive qualities on an individual basis. This is especially apparent in friendships with Explorers, whose strengths include spontaneity and the ability to take deep pleasure from the present moment – two traits that may not come naturally to Commanders. In particular, Commanders – who are at risk of over-thinking things – may be fascinated by Explorers' unencumbered embrace of their individual interests. Commanders are likely to be quite inspired by Explorers' remarkable tenacity, particularly given that it comes from a place of joy and engagement rather than obligation.

When they take an open-minded approach, Commanders recognize the value of such gifts, allowing their Explorer friends to be their true selves, even if those "true selves" aren't quite as rational or consistent as

Commanders might prefer. Appreciation of diverse merits helps them grow. By spending time with Explorer friends, they can expand their awareness of the world, engaging with fresh ideas and possibilities.

A Pleasant Surprise

To put it simply, Explorers can be great fun. Spontaneous and action-oriented, they take Commanders on unexpected, memorable adventures – which many Commanders crave. It can be tempting to think that rationality is incompatible with lighthearted fun, but that's hardly the case. Beneath their rational exteriors, Commanders thrum with wit and irreverent humor, and they enjoy a good time as much as anyone. By helping them relax and enjoy themselves, Explorers remind Commanders of an essential element of their true natures.

Such friendships can have wonderful energy and excitement. Commanders have so many ideas about what's possible, and Explorers prompt them to unbind their minds and take charge with even greater creativity. Commanders often have a strict way of thinking, but Explorers teach them to break their own rules and approach things from unexpected angles. If they happen to share a specific interest or hobby, it gets even better, and they can collaborate with their unique perspectives, sharing many days of fun and discovery.

Unbalanced Commander-Explorer Friendships

Differing Ideas About Engagement

Commanders may see Explorers' tendency to live in the present and follow their whims as shortsighted, and they may even disapprove of Explorers' tendency to move on from unfinished projects. On the other hand, Commanders' stubbornness and reluctance to let go can be very frustrating to Explorers, who may tire of hearing a steady stream of judgment about the importance of following through. When they fail to respect each other's approaches, frustration and resentment brew.

Tension may come to a boil during any type of activity, whether it's shared or not. It can be concerning for Commanders when Explorer friends get caught up in the drama or pleasure of the moment without taking time

for logical examination. However, they won't get a rational explanation from Explorers, who simply move on to the next thing before the dust settles. If Commanders spend too much time analyzing and criticizing, Explorers may simply leave. A lack of foundation for communication can lead these friends to become out of sync with each other.

The Rigid and the Reckless

Commanders might wonder whether their Explorer friends think of them as stodgy or boring. Explorers live in the moment, and they love to act on their desires. For some, that might mean checking out an expensive new restaurant they can't really afford. For more reckless Explorers, "adventures" might entail bridge jumping, rock climbing without proper precautions, or quitting a job without a backup plan. Regardless of the scenario, Commanders may see Explorers' spontaneity and risk-taking as dangerously shortsighted and stressfully unpredictable.

This isn't the foundation for a good friendship. Commanders can too easily fall into the role of the "stooge," acting almost like parents as they criticize their Explorer friends for not being more responsible. This, in turn, can spur Explorers to be more reckless to prove their independence. When friends react rather than respond to each other, neither is the best version of themselves. Inevitably, Commanders tire of caretaking and Explorers tire of Commanders' judgments, and one or both friends pull away.

Rebalancing Commander-Explorer Friendships

Why Bother?

Chances are that Commanders won't want to join all their exuberant Explorer friends' adventures. Their opinionated nature can make it difficult for them to feel excited about the concerts, art openings, or other events their Explorer friends suggest attending. They might also become frustrated if they get involved in undertakings that Explorer friends subsequently abandon, whether it's building a model airplane or taking a weekend road trip.

That said, if Commanders don't make any effort to share experiences with their Explorer friends, then friendship is likely to fade eventually.

As mature Commanders know, lasting relationships require effort and compromise, as well as quality time together. Although they can encourage their Explorer friends to stick with their undertakings, they can't force Explorers to follow through on activities that have lost their interest.

As such, Commanders need to relax their need for control at times, saying yes to their friends' ideas even if they might not work out. As a first step, Commanders might set a goal for how many times they'll say yes to Explorers' invitations. For example, they may aim to join close friends for an adventure at least once a week, or they might decide to say yes to at least one out of three invitations. Without that type of benchmark, it's easy to put off spending quality time together. Fortunately, Commanders are goal-oriented, and when they commit to maintaining their friendships, they follow through.

To find more enjoyment in the things they do with Explorer friends, Commanders can try the following:

- Re-label adventures as experiments. Choose a "lab notebook" in which to record observations.
- Identify a question that the experience can answer – for example, "Will trail running raise my heart rate higher than road running?"
- If time permits, consider doing research about the activity. Learning about trail running strategies and records, for example, might make the experience more interesting.
- Create a hypothesis for the above question. Decide how to measure the results.
- Note the results.
- Revisit the hypothesis and revise accordingly.
- If possible, conduct a follow-up experiment to verify results.

By focusing on an experiment, Commanders can enjoy their time with Explorers just as it is, rather than focusing on whether the activity comes to a successful or (in their minds) satisfactory conclusion. In their own way, Commanders care about being there for their friends. By sharing

new experiences with Explorers, they can broaden their horizons – and deepen their friendships.

How About This?

Commanders can take charge in their outings with Explorers by regularly proposing activities that suit their interests, meet their standards, and don't seem needlessly risky or fickle. This way, they won't end up criticizing their friends for failing to take them on well-planned activities. Just as importantly, they won't suffer through outings they don't enjoy, which can cause them to feel resentful or frustrated.

If their Explorer friends want to wander into the backwoods to camp and forage wild edibles, for example, Commanders can say "no thanks" this time – but another time offer to reserve an actual campsite with access to legendary trails and arrange to bring food. Or, if Explorer friends keep inviting Commanders to concerts they don't enjoy, they can turn the tables and suggest performances by artists they admire.

Here's how Commanders can propose more activities that they and their Explorer friends can enjoy together:

- Every time an Explorer's invitation is turned down, make a note of the type of event or outing offered (for example, an outdoor adventure, a music performance, an overnight trip).
- Research an alternative that sounds more enjoyable (for example, a concert by a performer you respect or an overnight trip to a place you'd like to visit).
- Finally, suggest these events or activities to Explorers in ways that convey excitement.

The above approach allows Commanders to temper their desire for control with spontaneity, particularly because they can depend on their Explorer friends to liven up their experiences. That said, please note that this strategy is designed to be used in tandem with the previous one above. ("Why Bother?") At times, Commanders benefit from saying yes to their Explorer friends' ideas – especially if the ideas draw them beyond their comfort zones.

Conclusion

Open Horizons

Commanders may be known for their independence, but this doesn't mean they don't benefit from fun, supportive friendships. When they open themselves to understanding and appreciating people with whom they may not share easy or immediate compatibility, they can discover a world of people who can offer good company, fresh perspectives, and consistent support. Friendships can be a much-needed source of happiness and personal fulfillment for Commanders, allowing them to develop open-mindedness, emotional awareness, and a sense of true belonging – all of which are important steps in their personal growth.

In return, Commanders bring many gifts to their friendships. Although emotional demonstrations don't come easily to them, they communicate their care through respect and loyalty toward their chums, as well as a willingness to step in and offer insightful yet practical help whenever it's needed. Offers of friendship from those with this personality type indicate deep appreciation and commitment; they aren't to be taken lightly.

Branching Out

Although Commanders might assume that they should look for friends who share their values, interests, and approaches to life, that isn't necessarily the case. Their unique combination of traits makes them rational and curious but not always open-minded, and they have deep values as well as a tendency to want to change the world to suit their own rational preferences.

Friendships with people who don't completely share their perspective might not provide obvious reassurance, but ultimately, such relationships create even greater gains. Although Commanders are known for their crisp, unconventional ideas, their creativity stalls if they surround themselves only with like-minded individuals. As they grow, people with this personality type come to respect capability and accomplishment in many forms, which allows for connections with people whose strengths differ from their own. By consciously engaging with others who challenge their worldview, Commanders can expand their minds, achieve new perspectives, and increase their abilities.

For these types, however, friendship isn't just about intellectual expansion. They also crave trustworthy friends who listen to them, stick with them through thick and thin, allow them to be their authentic selves, and bring fun and enjoyment to their lives. Thanks to the open-mindedness and emotional intelligence that they gain from their relationships, Commanders can learn how to establish deep, meaningful friendships – and maintain them over their lifetimes.

Parenthood

Commanders are typically up for a challenge. As a result, they're serious about the role they play when they become parents. They approach parenting with the utmost sense of personal responsibility. People with this personality type hold themselves to a high standard, and they view their children's success as reflecting those standards. They want to see their kids grow into smart, independent people who strive to achieve their goals.

Commanders are unlikely to hover over their children although they're likely to be present and involved to the degree their children need them. They may encourage their kids to extend themselves in the same outgoing way they do, which may not work for all children – especially those developing into more Introverted individuals.

Their high standards motivate Commander parents to focus on helping their children build their own values. They help their daughters and sons create a "code of conduct" that guides their thoughts and actions and helps them achieve their goals, and they hope their children interpret their encouragement as permission to be free to be themselves. They likely feel they parent best when their children end up finding and following their unique interests.

Commanders' aims are for their children to think for themselves and have a willingness to challenge the conventional. Commanders are prone to steer their kids toward embracing hard work as a value. They're most proud when they can label their kids "self-sufficient" and "proactive" in as many ways as possible.

Unfailingly Supportive

Commanders are consistent individuals who pride themselves on being responsible and organized, and such reliability is a valuable part of the parenting toolbox. Some parents may regard raising children as a responsibility or even a chore. Commanders typically embrace the challenge of bringing up children. They consider teaching their kids to succeed in the world to be a valuable effort filled with meaning and potential fulfillment that's worth their enthusiastic support.

Commanders are by and large carefully consider doling out praise and disciplinary consequences. Although not excessively warm, Commanders still bond with their children in their unique and caring way. They take pleasure in the progress their children make and the successes they achieve. These parents view each benchmark as noteworthy whether it's the first time they tie their shoes, their first spelling test they pass, or, as adolescents, when they first go out with friends on their own. While they may withhold gushing praise, they quietly and proudly make another checkmark on their mental list of their children's progress.

Expecting Too Much

As children develop, their sometimes-quirky behaviors can puzzle parents of any personality type, and Commanders are no exception. People with this personality type thrive on logic, intellectual arguments, and rational behavior, so the nonsensical antics of young children or adolescents can be baffling. No child has the mental or psychological capacity necessary to always behave rationally. Trial and error are essential parts of learning. It would be a mistake to consider even the most precocious children as "small adults" – complete packages in a compact form who respond properly to everything life throws at them.

Commanders' sometimes-stern opinions can come across as uncaring, even if they don't reflect their underlying feelings. Sometimes children need a shoulder to cry on, along with more rational life lessons. Learning to integrate rational instruction while providing emotional support may be one of the challenges Commanders must continuously address throughout their lifelong tenure as parents.

Determining Developmental Needs

It's important to remember that developmental milestones are rule-of-thumb measurements that aren't set in stone. Like all Analysts, Commanders love and trust systems and may feel more confident if their children stick close to fixed schedules as they progress through their youth. Kids who reach certain milestones earlier aren't necessarily "advanced." Likewise, those who achieve them later aren't always "delayed." Labeling children in such ways, especially very early in life, can be harmful to their development and their self-esteem throughout their lives.

Pediatricians and family physicians are parents' best resources for determining whether they should be concerned about their children's development. They can provide resources that cover what to expect at different stages regarding physical, intellectual, psychological, and behavioral development. Regular appointments with physicians can ensure that any issues are addressed in a timely manner, putting Commander parents' minds at ease.

Overly Critical

Criticism is another area where Commanders can miss the mark if they don't pay enough attention to this tendency. Their expectations may be excessive, so they may want to guard against becoming impatient when their children don't quickly pick up on what adults see as obvious. Commanders may overestimate their children's abilities and understanding, and perhaps become frustrated when their children don't meet their (sometimes unrealistic) expectations.

Commanders usually prize self-determination and intelligent action above most everything else. They value – and often expect – clarity and emotional stability in others. Parents who rely on rationality alone can alienate emotionally sensitive children by discounting their feelings. These types prefer to believe that the correct solution is the most efficient one, and they can have trouble softening their often-blunt opinions when dealing with their children.

Parenting for Each Stage of Development

Each stage of a child's growth presents unique challenges and exciting milestones. Learning how to navigate the stages can seem daunting, but the opportunity to build healthy attachments and create meaningful memories makes the struggle worthwhile.

Renowned psychologist Erik Erikson proposed a theory of psychosocial development comprised of eight stages, five of which take place between birth and 18 years of age. (The stages aren't set in stone, and the ages listed for each stage are approximate.) Children develop at their own pace and meet each milestone in their own time, sometimes skipping stages, achieving them in an unexpected order, or trying one milestone and falling back to an old one, which is especially common with babies who are learning to walk. It's worth developing healthy relationships with pediatric physicians to check in with any questions and concerns, as they can distinguish normal developmental delays from more serious concerns.

The following sections discuss some expectations for each stage of development, as well as how the strengths and weaknesses of the Commander personality type affect their parenting at each stage.

Commanders are hard-wired for helping their children through the developmental process. This doesn't mean they don't have blind spots to overcome. Parents of every personality type have a unique set of challenges to deal with, putting Commanders in the company of every other parent on the planet. A model like Erikson's offers Commanders, with their love of systems, a paradigm for better understanding their challenges and meeting them.

Building Bonds (Birth–1½ Years)

According to Erikson, the stages of infancy and early childhood last from birth until approximately three years of age. In these stages, children are very dependent on their parents to meet their needs. This is also when parents create bonds of attachment by meeting their babies' needs, developing trusting relationships, and promoting autonomy.

Trust versus Mistrust

Infancy, in Eriksonian terms, starts at birth and lasts about 18 months. The main developmental task of infancy involves deciding whether the world is a trustworthy place. If their caregivers nurture them

adequately and they achieve trust, children emerge from this stage with an overarching impression of the world as being reliable enough. They viscerally assign a reasonable amount of trust to other people, the environment, and the broader future. Not gaining trust leaves infants with a sense of the world being a frustrating or hostile environment that can't or won't satisfy their needs fully enough. They can come to interpret their environment as fundamentally undependable – and, in the extreme, even a dangerous place.

This stage has implications for future relationships, and it also affects feelings of overall confidence. If someone doesn't expect the world to meet their needs in a reasonable fashion regardless of what they do, they'll approach life tentatively and perhaps even defensively. They'll be likely to assume disappointment rather than success when they try to muster motivation.

Balanced Parenting During Infancy

Built-In Reliability and Experience

Consistency is essential to building trust in infants, and Commander parents attend to their infants' needs by feeding, changing, and comforting them diligently. Most Commanders already have formed precise systems for guaranteeing their lives run smoothly even before their children arrive. Adapting babies to their systems and having them enjoy the benefits of consistent, nurturing environments are almost effortless for most of these types. The sheer regularity of their care goes a long way to building such trust.

Chaotic environments create a sense of general distrust in impressionable infants, but Commander parents likely bring order instead. Infancy is an age of dependence, and these dependable parents help babies feel secure in their worlds. Commander parents are well-suited to welcome their newcomers into reliable environments worthy of their newborns' trust.

Plenty of Energy

Infancy is a trying time for parents because children at this age depend on their parents to provide for all their needs, regardless of the hour.

New parents to suffer from sleepless nights, so exhaustion comes with this stage. Commander parents have an advantage as they typically have high energy levels and aren't likely to tire quickly. Their Extravert energy carries them through these exhausting times.

Besides having the momentum to power through their sleep deprivation, Commanders' energy, when used effectively, helps insulate them from some issues caused by exhaustion. While by no means immune, they're less likely to feel anxious, sad, or overwhelmed. Commanders might even thrive on their infants' constant demands, as how to respond to such demands is yet another challenge for Commanders to conquer.

Unbalanced Parenting During Infancy

Not Always Affectionate

Although they're extraordinarily attentive and reliable, Commander parents may need to focus on regularly providing intentional affection. They may not always appreciate their babies' emotional needs. During the infant stage, babies who don't receive enough physical contact with caregivers may later struggle with bonding and trust. Commander parents aren't likely to deprive their children of touch, but they may see interactions with their infants as necessary rather than organic bonding opportunities. They may also look for more efficient ways of dealing with their children that don't involve something as unpredictable as emotions.

For example, Commanders may be tempted to let their children "cry it out" when it's time for them to sleep. Isn't coddling them reinforcing the crying, and wouldn't withholding the reinforcement extinguish the behavior? Both professionals and parents hotly debate this all the time. But most agree that children need regular reassuring contact. Infants need to be held, to be rocked, or to hear a soothing lullaby sung by their parents until they learn to self-soothe at night.

Adapting to their infants' unique needs can be especially frustrating for Commanders. They may hope for more efficient solutions to what are often lengthy and stubborn parenting problems. They may seek ways to streamline processes and force them to work faster. But anyone

who has properly raised children knows there are no shortcuts. It's an exhausting, hands-on process that often defies an organized path and sometimes calls for nothing more elaborate than physical contact and a warm presence. At this stage, touch may be the most valuable strategy available.

Rebalancing Parenting During Infancy

Interacting with Affection

Commanders are extraordinarily motivated and excel at parenting children through the infancy stage when they take the proper steps for overcoming their potential weaknesses. They're not always comfortable with their emotions. But cuddly infants, especially those who return their feelings through smiles, giggles, and other positive reactions, can bring out Commander parents' sensitive, silly, loving side.

It's important for Commanders to remember the value of touch and other ways of connecting with their babies. They may need to set up intentional ways of ensuring enough warm contact.

The following techniques can be useful for promoting both affection and bonding between Commander parents and their infants:

- Reciprocate children's laughter, facial expressions, and even hand motions. Infants bond by instinctively mimicking facial expressions, a phenomenon called "mirroring."
- Cuddle infants frequently and keep them close with wearable child carriers.
- Speak in a soothing voice, sing, and encourage eye contact. These actions help attachment and trust grow.

Physical affection is one of the most critical ways to both build attachment and promote infant growth and development. There's an added benefit of focusing on these types of interaction for Commanders who may devalue emotional displays. They're also tapping into their innate need to love and be loved, and hormones released during physical contact create lasting bonds between parents and children.

Testing Boundaries (1½–3 Years)

Autonomy versus Shame and Doubt

As Erikson noted, when young children become mobile, they become interested in exploring their environment with their senses. Emerging from the dependence of infancy, toddlers try on independence to see how well it fits. Crawling, walking, grabbing items, putting everything they find in their mouths, and attempting halting verbal communication are just a few ways that toddlers learn. Because of children's energy, curiosity, and constant engagement with their environments, exhausted parents have dubbed this period "the terrible twos." But by trying things out and exploring, children are setting the groundwork for their own independence, and patient Commander parents may find it to be an exciting time of discovery.

During this stage, parents must provide a safe harbor for their children while still allowing them to experience and explore their surroundings. Toddlers who can test boundaries yet receive parental support and encouragement develop a sense of autonomy. When adults excessively restrict, criticize, or make them feel guilty for their need to test boundaries, children experience a sense of shame, and they may also suffer from feelings of incompetence or low self-worth. By not developing a proper amount of independence, they may rely too much on external structures and directions from others. Such tendencies can last throughout their lives and can hinder their ability to achieve goals.

Balanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Eagerly Encouraging Learning

Increasing knowledge is a high priority for Commanders, and these Extraverted parents typically encourage their children to engage in activities where they can learn something. The exploration stage can be an exhilarating one, as it contains many milestones: talking, walking, learning how to use and manipulate toys and tools (such as forks and spoons), to name a few. Commander parents tend to provide their toddlers with plenty of stimulation and opportunities for exploration. As part of their exploration, children begin to express personal preferences, which are tiny steps toward solidifying a unique identity.

From reading books that spur the imagination to talking about their kids' life experiences as they occur, Commanders are likely to incorporate learning into everything, increasing their toddlers' knowledge and creating secure bonds between them. The more positive experiences that children have learning with their parents, the more likely they are to seek educational experiences in the future. Commanders who invest themselves by taking a supporting role and encouraging their toddlers' growth and learning lay the foundation for their sons and daughters to succeed.

Open-Minded and Curious

Commanders are open-minded and easily intrigued, making them just as interested in exploration as their children. This shared need to explore the world around them can be an incredible opportunity for both intellectual and emotional bonding. Commander parents have no problem understanding their children's impulse to explore, even when that means testing boundaries. They typically assist by providing the safe yet encouraging "home base" that their children need during their hands-on investigations of the world.

Many parents feel frustrated when their toddlers start to question everything (seriously, *everything*) and make their opinions known. Not so for Commanders. They may experience some of the same frustration, but they counter the feeling with a tinge of pride when their children ask questions that show they want to learn more. Constant questions that begin with "why" may try the patience of some parents, but Commanders are likely to try to provide satisfying, age-appropriate explanations. These parents are more than willing to entertain questions or challenges from children. They expect their kids to respect their authority – they won't deal with their questioning mid-tantrum – but little ones who ask thoughtful questions, or raise objections for good reasons, often receive thoughtful responses from their Commander parents.

Unbalanced Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Authority Issues

For Commanders who are insecure in their parenting abilities, this stage can be especially challenging. They may have trouble when children are disrespectful, which is sometimes part of their misguided attempts to grasp more independence. However, it can feel like a direct assault on Commander parents' authority – or, worse yet, a rejection of their love and direction. With their emotions so deeply hidden beneath the surface, parents with the Commander personality type may not even realize they want their children to return love and acceptance. These types show their love by providing guidance and knowledge – often authoritatively. If they don't receive the proper respect, they may become concerned about the depth of their children's love for them.

Commanders aren't offended by their toddlers' wishes to challenge the rules; however, this doesn't mean they'll accept disrespectful behavior if they believe it undermines their authority. This personality type can be rigid, and they may discover that their children's constant challenging of rules and boundaries causes tension. It also may hurt when their toddlers use their new favorite word – "No!" – forcefully and often. Commanders who view challenges to their authority as a rejection of love or respect may find this stage of child development to be the most difficult to endure. If they respond personally, their children may perceive that their explorations hurt others, which may cause a sense of shame and inhibit their attempts at autonomy.

Rebalancing Parenting During the Toddler Stage

Promoting Autonomy Through Positive Discipline

It's easy to become frustrated when children resist complying with those in charge, but it's important to understand their need to test boundaries at this stage. Toddlers must learn how to act independently and become self-reliant, and this sometimes means testing their parents' authority. At this stage, they seek both security and increased autonomy. Commanders must walk a fine line between supporting their children's need to explore and upholding important rules to ensure safety. Toddlers who disregard their parents' requests to stop throwing

their toys aren't doing so out of a lack of love or respect for their parents. It isn't personal. Rather, they're challenging the boundaries that their parents have put in place to learn how much independence their adult caretakers might allow in specific circumstances.

A strong, confident voice is essential for parenting, but parents should distinguish between that and a tyrannical, authoritarian voice. Commander parents promote their children's healthy autonomy through encouraging, understanding communication and positive discipline. It helps to look at the use of authority, specifically disciplinary actions, as learning opportunities for children rather than forms of punishment.

Redirection is one of the most effective tools parents can use when dealing with toddlers. This should be distinguished from distraction, where parents try to find something else to occupy their children's attention. Redirection, instead, focuses on addressing the underlying issues of the present circumstance and then finding workable alternative solutions. Consider the following example:

- Imagine a toddler is upset because they can't have a cookie before dinner, and they yell in response.
- Resist the urge to yell back or place them in time-out.
- Make eye contact and speak in a calm voice, saying, "I hear you saying that you would like a cookie. It's not okay to yell, so let's both talk about this using our quiet voices."
- Consider the underlying cause of the child's anger. If the child is asking for a cookie, odds are they're hungry – and hungry children are notoriously grumpy.
- Find a workable solution for all parties. Is there a healthier snack they can have? Could they taste a spoonful of the dinner that's being prepared? Would a glass of water help?
- Once the child calms down, talk to them about how yelling isn't likely to get them what they want.

Discipline should focus on teaching a lesson that helps toddlers develop a sense of autonomy. Taking the time at this stage to make sure that

children understand why specific behaviors are unacceptable helps them to realize what's expected of them, and it helps to improve their self-control. Commander parents also benefit from strengthening their relationships with their children by becoming sources of thoughtful wisdom rather than fuming mounds of anger and frustration.

Preschool to School Age (3–5 Years)

Initiative versus Guilt

Erikson highlighted the preschool years, ages three to five, as a prime time for brain development, and youngsters during this stage gather knowledge at an extraordinary rate. Children absorb information like sponges through constant activity and a broad range of questions. The Swiss psychologist, Jean Piaget, said, "Play is the work of childhood." Erikson reinforces this by stating that much of the learning that takes place at this stage comes through play – especially the unstructured kind. Using imaginary play and make-believe games and stories, creativity blossoms as children toy with the power of their own ideas. In addition, interaction with parents, teachers, and peers helps preschoolers grow socially.

When children can't practice launching activities, when their constant questions and childish make-believe play are dismissed as annoying, they may experience guilt, frustration, and a lack of confidence. They may suffer from poor self-control or a lack of initiative. To help their children navigate this stage successfully, Commander parents can aid them by providing opportunities for them to make their own decisions. Parents must suppress any tendency to be excessively controlling and allow their kids to begin activities, ask questions, receive answers, and lead others in exploratory play.

Balanced Parenting During Preschool

Competent Mentors

Commanders are imaginative, determined, quick-witted, and decisive individuals who excel at making plans and solving problems. They model these behaviors for their children and are likely to encourage their

preschoolers to play imaginatively and to practice creative problem-solving through activities like board games and puzzles. As a rule, Commander parents relish explaining various ideas, especially complicated ones, and enjoy their roles as intellectual guides who mold young minds.

Instilling a sense of curiosity, independent thinking, and high personal standards into their children from a young age is just as important to Commander parents as teaching their children any set of more concrete skills. They embolden their preschoolers to view everything as a learning opportunity. Something as simple as a walk around the neighborhood can be a spontaneous lesson on nature and geography, and a routine trip to the grocery store can develop rudimentary math skills.

Commander parents prompt their children to question everything. They try to instill curiosity and a love of learning from an early age, aligning their involvement closely with the stage's developmental tasks. However, they also need to provide enough freedom for their children to initiate their own activities. They should maintain an adequate balance between guiding their children and leaving them to their own devices.

Promoting Confidence

Besides providing endless information and learning opportunities for their preschoolers, Commander parents model independent thinking skills that also promote confidence. If kids at this stage lack confidence in themselves, they can become excessively dependent on others to lead, inform, or motivate them. Commander parents don't support passivity. Instead, they focus on helping their children feel confident and make choices on their own.

Commanders have well-developed decision-making skills and incredible initiative; both are qualities they can model for their children and encourage them to use. Self-assured parents with this personality type actively aid their kids in developing their own critical thinking skills. At this stage, for example, they might expect their children to use their problem-solving skills to smooth out conflicts with other kids. They're unlikely to pander to their preschoolers' wishes for them to solve their problems for them. Commanders see more value in helping their children figure out age-appropriate solutions for themselves.

Unbalanced Parenting During Preschool

Insensitive and Critical

Some Commander parents may put more emphasis on their children succeeding in academics and athletics by meeting benchmarks or scoring points rather than gaining more age-appropriate "wins." For example, they may cheer on their preschoolers when they score a soccer goal while ignoring the fact that they didn't pass the ball to the other players or display good sportsmanship.

Results-oriented Commanders may overlook the value of softer skills such as teamwork and fair play – important lessons in preschool soccer programs. Instead, they may measure their sons' and daughters' success only by the number of goals scored. Should their children not meet the more quantifiable results represented by goals, the message to the preschoolers might be they're "less than" in the eyes of their parents. In reality, their children may have succeeded wonderfully in the age-appropriate lessons intended. But those results may be less measurable in objective ways.

Their tendency toward insensitivity influences Commanders' interactions with their children. Even the most loving Commander parents may send harsh messages to their children – whether directly or indirectly. Preschoolers respond easily to criticism, and frequent confrontational communication or indirect messages of disapproval may provoke feelings of guilt that are difficult for young children to overcome. Telling them that their questions are "annoying" or "dumb" can be crushing during this phase. Measuring their achievements against standards that are too competitive or difficult at their age can be discouraging. With discouragement comes a sense of helplessness that can squelch any initiative they might have. Rather than experiencing their own potency as a growing human being, they instead wonder why they don't measure up when it comes to the most important people in their lives – their parents.

Excessively Logical

Some Commander parents fall flat when it comes to embracing unstructured or creative play. Those who fixate on their children's intellectual development may fall prey to the idea that free play isn't

as valuable as "educational" play or guided learning activities. They may focus their energy on providing learning experiences instead of allowing their little ones to find their own way and spontaneously explore their worlds.

Commanders love systems and may crave organized play, but sometimes it's better to leave their children's play unfettered. When taken too far, their organized approach may leave too little room for their children to make the discoveries – and the important mistakes – necessary for developing competence and initiative. Guidance is always a part of parenting, but preschoolers can't be programmed in some exact manner. Their learning experience is likely to be hindered if they don't have room to discover life on their own. Free play is better than a structured program at this age.

Rebalancing Parenting During Preschool

Increasing Compassion and Understanding

For Commander parents to support their children's self-confidence and teach them healthy social skills, they must practice compassion and understanding themselves. Excessive or unnecessary criticism is especially damaging to preschoolers. At this stage, children are just developing confidence in their abilities and the initiative to continue learning of their own accord. Too much negativity can easily stymie these efforts.

To prevent the guilt and withdrawal that may evolve when kids feel as though they're continuously wrong, Commander parents should reassess how they communicate with their preschoolers. Are they modeling compassionate communication? Are they patient when engaging in stressful conversations, or do they become critical? Do they promote empathetic behaviors such as concern when someone is sad, angry, or hurt? Or do they avoid other people who are expressing emotions? If they find they aren't communicating in ways that model compassion or understanding, Commanders can try the following activity:

- First, consider a situation that triggers an angry or critical response, such as preschoolers frequently ignoring their parents when they're asked to pick up their toys.

- Next, think about the "default" response that occurs.
  - Is there yelling?
  - Are threats made to take away (or throw away) toys that aren't picked up?
  - Are threats made about possibly sending the children to time-out?
  - Are the kids told that they're lazy, disrespectful, or naughty?
- Now, write down what about that behavior elicits an angry or critical response.
  - Are there feelings of disrespect on the parents' part?
  - Do the parents feel that their children don't like them?
  - Is there an underlying concern that the children are just plain "bad?"
- Instead of taking their kids' behavior personally, Commanders should consider ways to respond with understanding. In our example, they may not want to pick up their toys because they're having too much fun, or they may be very tired.
- Respond so it addresses the behavior with compassion rather than frustration.
  - "I know you're tired, but we need to pick up the toys before you lay down. Here, let me help you."
  - "I know you're having fun, but we have to go to the grocery store, so we need to pick the toys up now. Don't worry; you can play with them again when we get home!"

Understanding is the root of compassion. Taking the time to decipher their preschoolers' real intentions and needs allows Commander parents to connect with their children in valuable ways. Walking a mile in their little sneakers can go a long way toward positive parenting.

Promoting Creative Play

Learning to gauge their children's developmental readiness can be difficult for Commanders focused on achievement. Rather than constantly worrying about where their kids fall on the bell curve, they can focus on allowing them to develop more organically. Children don't need a constant itinerary of structured learning periods with just "educational" toys and games. Simple toys available "on demand" allow them to engage their imaginations – the first building block for growth.

Being flexible doesn't mean all play and no work. One way that Commander parents can promote both learning and autonomy without being too controlling is to allow their preschoolers to engage in imaginative, unstructured play. Consider playing house, pretending to be dinosaurs – with improvised costumes, perhaps – making up silly stories, or even playing a game of "hide-and-seek" to model the benefits of play and strengthen the parent-child bond. Unstructured playtime is important for children at this stage to gain competence, confidence, and initiative. Here are ideas for unstructured, child-led play that Commander parents can include in their plans for the day. They promote creativity and imagination in ways that structured play and video games cannot.

- A game of "Simon Says," where the children take the lead telling their parents what to do.
- Play that involves building or creating something from scratch, with materials such as blocks, clay, paper, crayons, or paint. (Consider setting these up in a place where messes can be contained.)
- Outdoor play, with natural items such as sticks, stones, dirt, and water, promotes creativity and imagination in ways that structured play and video games cannot.

Encouraging free, unstructured play doesn't mean that Commander parents must totally abandon educational play or learning activities. The key is finding a balance between structured activities and the freedom that children at this stage need to develop initiative and self-confidence.

School Age (5–12 Years)

According to Erikson, the elementary school years are an important period of skill development for young children. They aren't only absorbing new information. These children are refining their knowledge and using it to develop skills in increasingly complex ways – from relationships to school subjects to athletics. They develop even more autonomy as they head off to school to spend a large part of the day apart from their parents and families. Parents who challenge and support their kids in such pursuits help them flourish in both their abilities and their self-confidence.

This stage is somewhat of a Goldilocks scenario: Children don't benefit from either "too hot" or "too cold" parenting. If they don't receive enough consistent support and achieve enough success at this stage, they can feel inferior to their peers and become so demoralized that they're less likely to work toward achieving long-term goals on their own. But if adults make everything too easy for them and they aren't sufficiently challenged, kids may assume undeserved confidence in themselves and their abilities. This can lead to a sense of entitlement that leaves them unmotivated to try harder. Parents must allow their children to hit a few of life's potholes on their own. Experiencing the valuable lessons that come from trial and error helps them deal with life and all its imperfections – theirs and everyone else's.

Balanced Parenting During the School-Age Years

Encouraging Expertise

As parents, Commanders have no trouble challenging their children to improve themselves and to set and achieve increasingly ambitious goals, though children's goals may not always take forms expected or appreciated by their parents. However, becoming expert in any field is important to Commanders, so they take every opportunity to promote their children's drive to increase their knowledge and skills. Are their kids passionate about dinosaurs? Parents with this personality type are likely to provide them with books, educational videos, and museum trips galore.

Not ones to settle for merely "learning about something," Commander parents place much emphasis on developing competence. They work to

inspire their sons and daughters to build skills and abilities, especially in their intellectual development. Although Commanders prize intelligence, they're no strangers to the value of basic hard work and a passionate approach, and they encourage their children, regardless of levels and abilities, to achieve their personal best.

Supporting, Setting, and Achieving Goals

Setting and achieving goals are integral to children's learning at this stage, and Commander parents are happy to model the focus and determination necessary to succeed. School-aged children face steadily increasing expectations at school and elsewhere. They gain much from those who can teach them how to meet expectations strategically. Parents with this personality type take pleasure in sitting down with their kids to help them map out the steps to achieve academic, social, and personal objectives.

Developing long-term goals is challenging for children who lack the maturity to plan effectively. This skill becomes increasingly necessary during the school-age years, and Commander parents can draw on their own experience with planning and setting goals to help their daughters and sons prepare for projects. ("Ok, you want to make a solar-powered toilet for the science fair? Let's figure out what you need, and the time needed, so that you can make the best potty possible.") They can also provide their kids with the resources to achieve specific goals. ("You want to make the swim team this year? Great! I'll take you to the pool, so you can practice.")

Unbalanced Parenting During the School-Age Years

Pervasively Critical

Commanders can become so focused on succeeding and doing things perfectly that they may erode their children's confidence with unrelenting streams of criticism. Sometimes the criticisms are blatant: "There's no excuse for less-than-perfect grades. Anything less than an 'A' is unacceptable." Other times, they may engage in criticism less obviously through body language or by highlighting the achievements of more "successful" peers or siblings too often.

When Commanders carry over their own perfectionist tendencies into their parenting, they may subconsciously expect negative results when they interact with their children. When assuming the worst becomes their default, Commander parents may cause their kids to feel the constant presence of disapproval, which can negatively affect the confidence they need to develop skills and to acquire a sense of competency.

Overwhelming Expectations

It's possible for Commanders to push an achievement-oriented view on unwilling children – those more interested in building relationships than becoming stars of the basketball team or valedictorian of their class, for example. Sometimes ambitious parents may see their children's performance as being more about their success as parents than their kids' reasonable progression through a developmental stage. Constant pressure to perform in pursuit of higher levels of success can overwhelm sensitive children, making them feel inadequate and unworthy of their parents' love. Sometimes, Commander parents who take a tough-love approach may do much more harm than good to children's self-esteem.

School-aged kids who feel constant pressure and little support may become withdrawn – pulling away from the people and circumstances causing the pressure. Or, they may act out, expressing their frustration in unhealthy ways. While the pressure they place on their sons and daughters may be the product of good intentions, Commanders who don't consider their children's emotional needs may unintentionally damage their relationships with them.

Rebalancing Parenting During the School-Age Years

Becoming an Active Listener

It's important for Commander parents to balance their need for perfection with compassion and support. Peers and teachers exert an increasing influence on school-aged children, but parents still take the lead in developing kids' skills, goals, and self-esteem. Commanders who struggle with excessively perfectionist tendencies or competitive natures must try to decrease their criticism and focus on empathizing with their children. As ambitious as they are, and as successful as they

hope their children can be, they must learn to temper their motivation with compassion.

Active listening is one of the most effective ways to practice compassion. The following suggestions can help Commander parents to develop active listening skills to communicate with their children more compassionately and effectively:

- Take time to listen to kids' concerns, questions, and frustrations. Listen first, before focusing on how to solve their problems.
- Don't interrupt.
- Pay attention to body language. Consider sitting or kneeling on the same level. Use postures and expressions that confirm listening.
- Once time has been taken to improve understanding of their situations, focus on working with them to help them find solutions (if necessary).
- Remember, it's also important for parents to practice non-judgment when actively listening to children. Listening is usually more important than offering an opinion – an important skill to learn when communicating with children and adults alike.

Compassion, effective communication, and thoughtful perspectives are all products of active listening. But active listening has the added benefit of allowing children to define their own problems and explain their circumstances. Commander parents who practice patience and a light touch can help kids develop critical thinking skills during the process. Active listening allows Commanders to empower their children further.

Focusing on Comprehensive Development

Challenging their children to improve is a worthy goal for all parents. That said, constantly pushing them to exceed their limits is likely to cause more harm than good. Kids' confidence decreases when they believe they aren't meeting their parents' expectations, causing them to either withdraw or act out in frustration. Commanders who believe they're doing their children a favor by pushing them to succeed may be in for a rude awakening when they discover they're pushing them away.

These parents can learn to balance their expectations with a more comprehensive approach to their children's growth. Gaining competence is important during this stage, but it means much more than doing well in school, clubs, or sports. School-aged children spend more time interacting with others outside their families and developing their own identities, so learning healthy emotional and social intelligence is essential. Commanders who can recognize (and help with) their daughters' and sons' growth in areas other than intellectual development are more likely to strike a sensible balance. Here are some concepts that may help Commander parents:

- Promoting (and practicing) healthy emotional awareness and expression: Understanding what emotions are being experienced, and then expressing them properly and effectively, are among the most challenging – but most rewarding – skills parents can learn alongside their children. Charts are available online that can help youngsters of all ages label what they're feeling.
- Engaging with empathy: To communicate in an efficient and considerate way, it's essential to look at the situation from others' point of view. After actively listening to kids, paraphrase their experiences and try to apply both logic and feelings to the events in their lives.
- Practicing impulse control: Parents who control their behavior and desires promote self-discipline, one of the most necessary skills for achieving success and building healthy relationships. Although this isn't generally hard for Commanders, children can try their patience. It's helpful if these parents remember to keep their responses measured and aligned with their children's developmental needs.
- Forgoing criticism and focusing on the positive: If criticism is necessary, try to balance it out with praise and/or hope, either in the moment or later. For example, "I know you're disappointed about not making the team. I'm really proud of you for trying out. I bet if you practice regularly for the next few months, you'll have an even better shot next season. I'll help you make a practice schedule." Always make any criticism about specific behaviors, not overall worth. Let kids know that all competent and good people make mistakes and fail sometimes.

Kids thrive when they have the confidence to be themselves. When their lives are in balance, they're happier in the moment, and more successful in their future efforts. Building the above skills pays big dividends for children later in life, and it also promotes healthy relationships – including their relationships with their Commander parents.

Adolescence (12–18 Years)

Identity versus Role Confusion

This transitional period centers on kids' sense of what their roles are in their relationships with themselves, others, and society in general. To resolve their roles, adolescents in this stage begin the all-important process of identifying their personal values and beliefs. During this pivotal stage, they make educational and pre-career decisions, and develop relationships based on how all those things align with their values and beliefs.

Erikson described adolescence as a time for children to refine their true selves and distance themselves to a degree from their identification with their parents and family members. Life takes some of the focus off their external behaviors, like in the earlier stages, by adding the impactful internal questions, "Who am I? What part do I play in the world from here on out?" These questions add new depth during this time of growth, and a sense of unique identity emerges when this stage is successfully executed.

Typically, society allows leniency (sometimes reluctantly) for adolescents to experiment to "find themselves" during this period as they test various roles. Take, for instance, teenage fads and trends that baffle adults. Sometimes, it's as routine as the adolescents trying out different clubs, school electives, or various social groups. Some parents may be pleasantly surprised to see a wholesome value arise independently because of something their teens experienced.

Whatever the result (and however jarring it may occasionally be to the adults in their lives), some amount of experimentation is necessary before teenagers can successfully form their own adult identities. Should adolescents not "find themselves" during this period, they may face a confusing lifetime quest that keeps them always searching and never fully deciding their purpose or direction.

Balanced Parenting During Adolescence

Encouraging Exploration

As in their toddler years, adolescents find themselves in a transitional stage focused on exploration. This time, however, they focus their exploration on their identities, rather than exploring their external environments. The work of adolescence is largely internal as they seek to reconcile who they are with the world around them. Commander parents who embrace their thirst for knowledge as a tool for personal improvement can be exceptional models for this growth.

Parents who embrace their own sense of confidence in fulfilling their personal visions can also model their passion for learning for their teens. Learning new skills or mastering new topics take curiosity and dedication, and Commanders have ample amounts of both. Their natural need to learn and excel is obvious, and their kids witness such behavior regularly. These types encourage their sons and daughters to explore their interests, regardless of whether those interests are "useful" or "practical," and this support can be the confidence boost that adolescents need to chase their passions.

Promoting a Code of Conduct

During this stage of identity development, teens need the support and understanding of their parents more than ever. One of the essential facets of personal growth for Commanders is their development of a "code of conduct" they can use to support their character and their actions. Those who remain open to others' perspectives and needs can encourage their children to develop their own unique code of conduct as well; ideally, their sons and daughters can find one that resonates with them and isn't reliant solely on external and social pressures. If their code of conduct encourages hard work and ambitious goals, Commander parents tend to let their children fill in the blanks to meet their personal needs and wishes.

These parents encourage their children to develop this code of conduct by promoting and modeling such positive values as efficiency, confidence, and lifelong learning, while providing an encouraging environment for their teens. They may struggle with less control over their kids over time – especially as their adolescents claim

more independence, as most do. Nonetheless, Commanders remain interested in helping their kids' personal development – in fact, most people with this personality type strongly agree that teens need to be ready adults by the end of adolescence.

Unbalanced Parenting During Adolescence

Demanding Authoritarians

Parents who have an authoritarian bent, as Commanders sometimes do, may struggle with this tumultuous stage of development. Young adults in this phase of life are grappling with their expanding independence and the responsibilities that come with it, and they often need the benefit of an understanding conversation with their parents to negotiate new expectations and experiences. Commanders who obsess on enforcing prevailing (and perhaps outdated) rules too rigidly may butt heads with their teens, with little good to show for it.

There's a significant difference between being *authoritative* and being *authoritarian* as parents. Authoritative parents are trustworthy, reliable, and considerate caregivers who clearly know what they're talking about. Authoritarian parents focus on strict obedience to authority regardless of specific circumstances. Commander parents who don't adjust their grip on their children as they mature may push their growing teenagers away, as their basic developmental job demands they explore ways to stand on their own two feet.

Teens often feel a tinge of resentment, even with the most reasonable rules. Adolescents who feel that their parents disrespect – or resent – their newfound drive for independence may come to lack the confidence and motivation to pursue their personal development, both in the moment and later in life.

Overly Judgmental

To kids at this stage, critical comments can be devastating, especially those about their abilities or personal style. They already feel constantly judged, and the many changes that come at this time of life often have them feeling awkward in their own skins. Teens who are coming to terms with who they want to be versus how society views them often

have a fragile enough sense of self. Commander parents who constantly move the goal posts for success ("Good thing you passed that test – but next time, shoot for an 'A.'") can undermine their children's self-esteem and their relationships.

Constant criticism and reminders of any previous missteps their kids may have made can breed resentment. Rather than forgiving their misdeeds and helping their teens deal with the results of their actions, judgmental Commanders may focus on holding mistakes over their children's heads as reminders of their failures. They may believe this is the best way to ensure that their sons and daughters won't repeat their errors. Unfortunately, more often than not, such unconstructive criticism strikes the recipients as mean and unfair. Adolescence need understanding and context to help them learn from, and eventually overcome, their struggles. Habitual parental responses that have them feeling chronically "less than" aren't helpful during this time of life – if ever.

Rebalancing Parenting During Adolescence

Adjusting Expectations

As Commander parents learn to navigate their children's changing needs and growing independence, they must occasionally change course. This stage requires constant rebalancing of responsibility and expectations as adolescents become more capable, responsible, and mature. Parents with the Commander personality type may struggle to reduce the control they exert over their kids. This isn't necessarily because they view their teens as incapable but, rather, because they believe themselves to know more – and they probably do. However, leaving room for flexibility and exploration fosters adolescent children's identity development, allowing them to feel capable by providing them the space to pursue the important task of achieving independence.

Commander parents who wish to encourage their children's personal growth and independence while still preserving structure and boundaries can promote their children's self-discipline. Adolescents who can engage in self-discipline – tapping into their values and knowledge to choose the right decision and delaying gratification

when necessary – are much more likely to be healthy, independent, and successful adults. Authoritative parenting allows children to learn discipline for themselves.

One example of fostering self-discipline is to teach adolescents how to manage their emotions – an especially difficult task at this stage – using the "ABCDE" method. To utilize this technique effectively, however, Commander parents must remain sympathetic to their children's needs, and avoid forcing them to apply reason in the heat of their emotions. Allowing teens a chance to vent and then cool down can lead to the more meaningful practice of the ABCDE exercise.

The ABCDE method, step by step, is as follows:

- A: Identify an **a**ctivating event.
  - Example: Failing a driver's license test.
- B: Determine the irrational **b**eliefs that resulted from the event.
  - The test was impossible; the test-taker was not smart enough to pass.
- C: Consider the emotional **c**onsequences of those beliefs.
  - Anger, frustration, and sadness that results in their yelling at their parents; they lose faith in their ability to succeed.
- D: **D**ispute or challenge the irrational beliefs.
  - Discuss the irrational belief, like an impossible test or their own stupidity, and determine whether the event was more likely caused by a lack of study and practice, leading to test anxiety or knowledge gaps.
- E: Replace irrational beliefs with new, **e**ffective beliefs that result in positive behaviors.
  - More study and practice before retaking the driver's license test can increase knowledge and improve confidence, hopefully preventing test anxiety and resulting in a passing score.

Commanders may have to help their adolescent children through the ABCDE process a few times before teens are comfortable practicing it on

their own. With this technique, teens can eventually learn how to handle their emotions. These are the foundational skills behind self-discipline. Commander parents who practice with their children can help them to develop the tools they need to function most effectively on their own.

Cultivating Positive Communication

Even when they're at their most judgmental, Commander parents are caring. They want their children to be happy and successful. Hassling their kids for less-than-perfect grades, or criticizing their wish to get degrees in fields they judge to be "not worthwhile" ("Art history? That's a hobby, kid."), they may dishearten their teens when they only intended to support them. Commanders want what's best for their children, but how they communicate that sentiment can become muddled by their opinions and "know-it-all" attitude.

Commander parents' first step to solving the communication problem includes seeing a torrent of criticism, or their tendency to constantly point out their children's logical fallacies, as missing the mark. That doesn't mean there isn't room for measured correction if expressed in a way that's respectful of the adolescents' honest efforts and interests and their inherent value as people.

Counseling is a better model than critiquing. Telling adolescent children everything that's wrong with their ideas/beliefs/clothes/taste in music may seem effective. But a constant focus on the negative can erode both their teens' confidence and the parent-child relationships. Approaching communication in an encouraging, positive way, without judgment or condemnation, can improve their rapport and increase their children's confidence and self-determination.

The following tips can help Commanders communicate with their adolescent children in a much more positive, productive way:

- Suspend judgment – to prevent potential misunderstandings, don't jump to conclusions or make assumptions about motives, beliefs, or opinions.
- Don't discount feelings – to communicate in honest, open ways, adolescents must feel as though their parents are considering their feelings.

- Avoid arguing – nothing escalates a simple conversation to a full-blown fight faster than being combative.
- Speak compassionately – be intentional about not expressing things in a condescending, angry, or critical way when engaging in a conversation.

To be clear, Commander parents are hardly ogres at heart, and they often come from a place of good intentions. But they can be blunt and focused to the point they may not read their audiences well. Their audience, in this case, is their sensitive adolescent children who are likely having a challenging enough time dealing with some major life changes without the perception of parental hostility. Expediency and order can sometimes mean addressing feelings, egos, and other sensitivities before gently guiding teens who may not be in the mood for advice.

Conclusion

Parenting is one of the most challenging experiences that anyone can face, regardless of their personality type. Commanders have their own unique strengths – imagination, open-mindedness, determination, and dedication – that they can use to parent successfully, as well as weaknesses that they need to understand and balance to build positive relationships with their children. Parenting brings enormous potential for personal development, and Commanders can gain a much deeper understanding of themselves and others if they use the opportunity to do so.

The advice provided in this chapter considers the general growth stages for children, as well as the basic strengths and weaknesses that many Commanders share. All children are different, and parents are the best judges of what their children need. Readers should use the advice above in a way that works best for their families without adding unmanageable stress, frustration, or burden. For special circumstances, such as persistent behavioral or medical issues, consult with a professional pediatrician or pediatric psychologist to develop a plan that addresses the needs of everyone involved.

Final Words

Balanced Relationship Goals

Cultivating robust social skills may be as important for Commanders as the fulfilling relationships that likely come as a result. Habitually exercising personal ability is a core facet of this personality type, and boosting their social skill set can be both a practical advantage in life as well as a point of pride. It's true that compared to many personality types, Commanders may not prioritize the formation and maintenance of social bonds – or even emotional expression and empathy. But having the ability to do so when desired – or needed – is likely an essential avenue of growth that contributes to their lifelong happiness. That's due in large part to the requirements of sustained relationships with others whose needs and preferences differ from Commanders' own.

Relationship goals are rarely unilateral, and as much as Commanders may possess a clear vision of what they want and how to achieve it, other voices will also have their say. Practicing the art of establishing a fair and fulfilling balance between their own goals and those of others is a key skill that helps Commanders make their relationships as joyful as possible. More than just rational compromise, this balance comes from pursuing a true understanding of people's thoughts and feelings. There's a difference between understanding that something is important to someone and understanding *why* it's important to them. Likewise, what people say and how they feel often differ, and unraveling the truth in relationships requires paying attention to many levels of communication. Unfortunately, Commanders cannot always depend on others to be open and direct about what they want.

Consequently, creating and sustaining balance in any social relationship requires some trial and error, as well as accepting a certain level of inefficiency. Relationship goals won't necessarily feature clear paths, and one person cannot reasonably shoulder the responsibility for planning the route or carrying the other forward on it. Commanders achieve balance when they accept that healthy relationship goals are created mutually, from elements of all the hearts and minds involved.

The Needs of the Self

This e-book has highlighted many challenges (and benefits) that Commanders are likely to encounter in the social realm. Some of those

challenges have been laid at the feet of Commanders themselves, including potential issues with emotional awareness and expression. It's important to note that while growth in such areas is certainly beneficial to Commanders' lives, nothing in this book is meant to imply that there's anything wrong with the natural style and preferences of people with this personality type.

The emotional intimacy that can be found in the world of social relationships can be among the most profoundly fulfilling experiences in life. But the manner and pace in which Commanders choose to engage with such opportunities must be guided by their own genuine desires and needs, not a prescribed ideal or the expectations of others. Intense rationality, emotional reserve, independence, and a direct communication style are not flaws to be fixed or ashamed of. These are aspects of the Commander personality that can be utilized as strengths in the appropriate contexts. As Commanders move through different situations in life, they can distinguish for themselves what works, what could work better, and what they're comfortable with. They add skills, knowledge, and methods to their personal repertoire as needed to match their evolving life goals.

All the guidance and insights offered in this e-book are intended to expand, not remake, what Commanders are – and, perhaps, to inspire people with this personality type to step beyond their current selves, not merely because the need arises but because they might uncover hidden rewards. Options and opportunities abound in the world of social relationships, and Commanders who dare to act on positive potentials are likely to find many pleasant surprises waiting for them. Yet to be truly happy with any relationship, it must be their own desires that drive them to seize what awaits. Commanders can honor the needs of the self even as they boldly step forward to change, grow, and embrace new experiences.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want to analyze and improve your relationships with your romantic partner, friends, or children? Explore our Relationships Specialized Tests.
- Looking to set a foundation for learning and developing as a person? Check out the *Commander Guide to Personal Growth*.
- Feeling adrift when it comes to your academic path or your career? Our *Commander Guide to Careers* may be just what you need.

All contents copyright ©2011–2023 NERIS Analytics Limited. All rights reserved. This document is intended for personal use only and no part of it may be translated, shared, reproduced or transmitted in any form, by any means (electronic, photocopying, recording, or otherwise) without the prior written permission of the publisher.

The publisher has used its best efforts in preparing this document, and the information provided herein is provided "as is." NERIS Analytics Limited will assume no liability nor responsibility to any person or entity with respect to any loss or damage related directly or indirectly to the information in this document (including any action or inaction taken or not taken as result of the information contained herein). Any decisions that you make once you have read this document are for you alone and we won't be liable for the consequences of any such decisions.

No warranties of any kind, express or implied, are made, and the publisher specifically disclaims any implied warranties of fitness for any particular purpose. The publisher will provide no remedy for indirect, consequential, punitive, incidental, or other damages arising from this document, including such from negligence, strict liability, or breach of warranty or contract, even after notice of the possibility of such damages.

The publisher is not engaged in rendering legal, medical, financial, or other professional services. The information in this document is educational in nature, is provided only as general information, and is not psychological advice. Transmission of this information is not intended to create, and receipt doesn't constitute a psychologist-client relationship. Furthermore, this information is not intended to be used to diagnose, treat, cure, or prevent any disease or psychological disorder.

This document is only available for purchase at https://www.16personalities.com. If you have downloaded this document from any other website or if it has been included in any service not provided by NERIS Analytics Limited, please be aware this is very likely an unauthorized copy. In such and similar cases, we would be very grateful if you could get in touch with us via our website at https://www.16personalities.com/contact-us so that we could investigate. Thank you!